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碩士論文

創意階層引領下的曼谷嵩越路老街再生研究
Creative-Elites Led Regeneration in Songwat Old
Neighborhood, Bangkok

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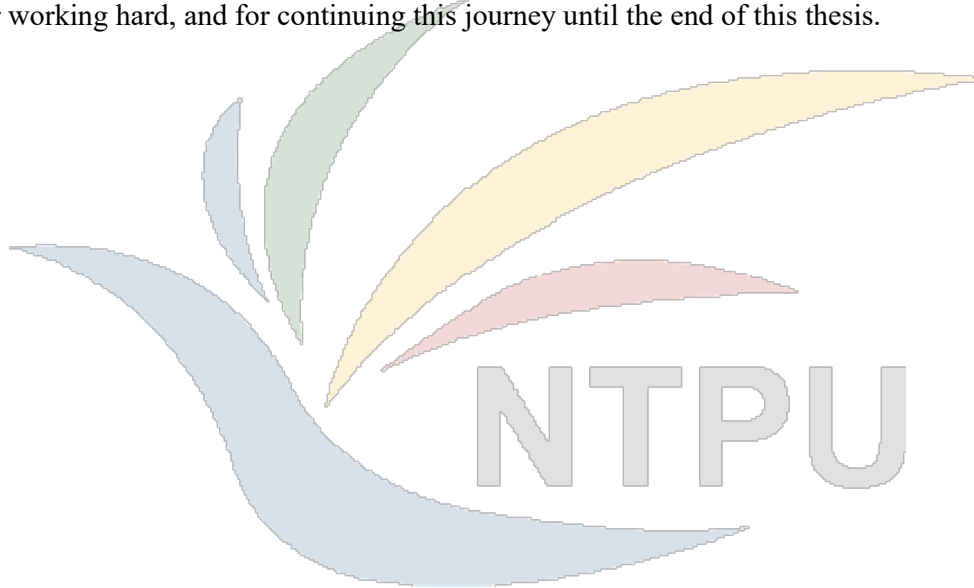
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**National Taipei University
International Program on Urban Governance
Master Thesis Verification**

創意階層引領下的曼谷嵩越路老街再生研究

Creative-Elites Led Regeneration in Songwat Old Neighborhood,
Bangkok

This is to certify that the Master thesis above is completed by Tanawan Samphanthamas – 711276712 during her studying in the International Program on Urban Governance at National Taipei University, and that the oral defense of this thesis is passed on 01/26/2026 in accordance with the decision of following committee members:

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摘要：

本論文探討曼谷嵩越老街區的創意導向再生如何展開，說明這條昔日的中泰批發街如何轉變為臨河的創意與文化遺產區域。研究關注是誰啟動了這場再生進程、哪些個人、經濟與空間因素形塑了他們的角色，以及包括公部門與私部門在內的關鍵利害關係人之間的協作如何推動嵩越的再生。

本研究採用質性單一個案研究法，結合對創意企業家、家族企業接班人、「Made in Songwat」團體成員、以及曼谷市政府（BMA）與泰國創意經濟促進機構（CEA）官員的訪談，同時輔以文件分析與田野觀察，涵蓋日常時段與「Awakening Songwat」等活動。研究結果顯示，區域變遷並非由單一旗艦型計畫主導，而是由多個在地行動者共同推動；創意菁英將閒置的歷史騎樓店屋改造為咖啡館、藝廊、精品旅宿與混合型家族商業空間，並在僅具象徵性且實質支持有限的政策框架下逐步發展。

研究指出，長期的物流功能衰退使嵩越密集的店屋紋理得以保存，為新一代創業者開啟重塑街區的空間，讓他們得以運用家族傳承、專業技能與多層級網絡重新形構此地區。這些變化一方面升級了建成環境並促進地方經濟多元化，另一方面也帶來關於能見度不均、地價上升，以及大型企業主導的臨河巨型開發計畫風險等張力，這些發展可能進一步加深受益分配上的不平等。本論文透過對歷史商業街區創意導向再生的分析，回應「創意城市」、地方營造與創意菁英相關論辯，揭示草根網絡與深植地方的城市行動者如何共同形塑當代曼谷「創意」都市轉型的可能性與侷限。

關鍵詞：創意帶動型都市再生、創意菁英、場所營造、嵩越路老街區

ABSTRACT

CREATIVE-ELITES LED REGENERATION IN SONGWAT OLD NEIGHBORHOOD, BANGKOK

by

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This thesis examines how creative-led regeneration in Bangkok's Songwat Old Neighborhood has unfolded, as a former Chinese-Thai wholesale street has been transformed into a riverside creative-heritage area. It investigates who initiated this regeneration, which personal, economic, and spatial factors shaped their roles, and how collaboration among key stakeholders, including public- and private-sector actors, drives Songwat's regeneration.

Using a qualitative single-case study, the research combines interviews with creative entrepreneurs, family-business successors, members of the Made in Songwat collective, and officials from the Bangkok Metropolitan Administration (BMA) and Creative Economy Agency (CEA), together with document analysis and field observation during everyday periods and events such as Awakening Songwat. The findings show that change emerges from many local actors rather than one flagship project, as creative elites adapt underused historic shophouses into cafés, galleries, boutique stays, and hybrid family-business spaces, supported by policy frameworks that offer symbolic and limited practical support.

The study shows how long-term logistical decline kept Songwat's dense shophouse fabric intact, opening room for a new generation of entrepreneurs to reshape the area by drawing on family legacies, professional skills, and multi-level networks. These changes upgrade the built environment and diversify the local economy but also create tensions around unequal visibility, rising land values, and the risks of large corporate-led riverside megaprojects, which may deepen inequalities in who benefits. The thesis contributes to debates on creative cities, placemaking, and creative elites by examining creative-led regeneration in historic commercial districts, showing how grassroots networks, and embedded urban actors jointly shape the possibilities and limits of "creative" urban transformation in contemporary Bangkok.

Keywords: Creative-led urban regeneration, Creative elites, Placemaking, Songwat Old Neighborhood

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Chapter1

Introduction

1.1 Introduction

Urban regeneration in Bangkok's Songwat district represents a dynamic intersection of creative leadership, community engagement, and heritage preservation. Historically a hub of river-based commerce and Chinese merchant activity, Songwat today is witnessing a transformation led by creative elites, including entrepreneurs, artists, designers, and successors of family businesses—who are reimagining its cultural assets for adaptive reuse and urban innovation.

Bangkok's Songwat neighborhood is a historic riverside district where long-established businesses, new creative businesses, and government agencies are increasingly interacting as part of an emerging urban elite network. This area offers a helpful perspective for analyzing how well-connected officials, businesspeople, and artists establish and preserve relationships, plan initiatives, and collaborate to influence continuous regeneration. As a result, Songwat is an excellent location for researching how urban elites collaborate and influence authority in the midst of Bangkok's rapid urban and cultural transformation.

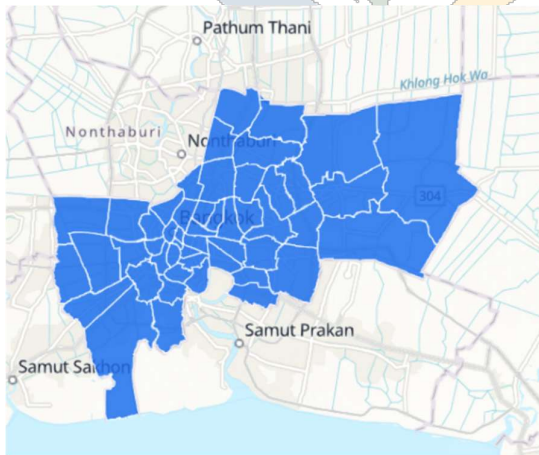


Figure 1.1 : Map of Bangkok
(Photo Source : ArcGIS, 2019)

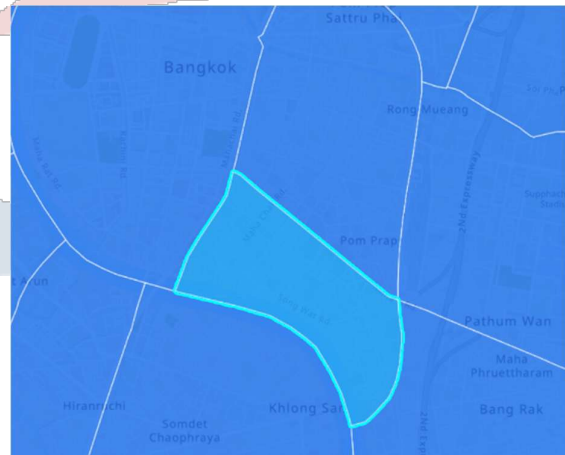


Figure 1.2 : Samphanthawong District, Bangkok
(Photo Source : ArcGIS, 2019)



Figure 1.3 : Samphanthawong District, which Songwat road located (Photo Source : ArcGIS, 2019 adapted by author)

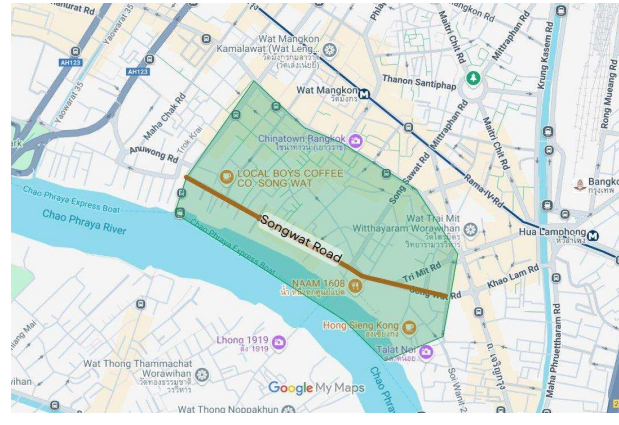


Figure 1.4 : Area around Songwat road (Photo Source : Google Maps, 2025 adapted by author)

My childhood travels through areas such as Yaowarat, Phuket Old Town, and Kim-Yong in Hat Yai inspired my interest in urban entrepreneurial legacies and family businesses. Family-owned businesses are key to maintaining social capital, community identity, and intergenerational entrepreneurship in these districts; they are more than just businesses (Suvarnananda, 2024). My thesis focus and research methodology have been shaped by these experiences, which have grounded my analysis in both firsthand experiences and academic fieldwork throughout Bangkok's regeneration neighborhoods.

Songwat's revitalization is propelled by a multi-level partnership among public agencies such as the Bangkok Metropolitan Administration (BMA), the Creative Economy Agency (CEA), and the Tourism Authority of Thailand (TAT), alongside local entrepreneurial actors and collective networks like "Made in Songwat".

The BMA's 20-year strategic plan, known as "Bangkok Vibrant of Asia," emphasizes participatory workshops, stakeholder collaboration, and integration of diverse perspectives to align local needs with metropolitan and international aims (BMA, 2013). These processes are complemented by grassroots creativity, where local entrepreneurs lead adaptive reuse of shophouses and warehouses—creating vibrant cultural venues, boutique hotels, and fusion cafés that celebrate the area's multicultural heritage (CEA and Partners, 2023).



Figure 1.5 : CEA and Partners signed MOU to boost Thailand’s Creative Economy through Creative Business Transformation (Photo source : BANGKOKPOST, 2023)

Organization/Group’s name	Type	Roles in Songwat Neighborhood
Bangkok Metropolitan Administration (BMA)	Public	Started a comprehensive development plan for regenerating historic neighborhoods like Songwat, With a strategic "Bangkok: Vibrant of Asia”
Creative Economy Agency(CEA)	Public	Supporting the transformation of creative businesses, connects local creative products to both domestic and international markets, collaborates across private and public sectors.
Made in Songwat	Private	Community-driven initiative, made Songwat sustainable, inclusive, and settled growth.

Table 1.1: Key stakeholders in Songwat regeneration (BMA, 2013; CEA, 2023)

Creative elites play a pivotal role in Songwat’s ongoing transformation. Their initiatives drive economic growth, tourism, and job creation while preserving traditional customs and social networks. Songwat exemplifies a unique fusion of Thai, Chinese, Muslim, and Indian influences, reflected through its vibrant business creativity and cultural hybridity visible in local products, art, and cuisine (Phelps & Miao, 2020). Through innovative events and strategic branding, the area has emerged as a showcase of Thailand’s creative economy within the

broader national agenda for soft power and participation in international creative markets (CEA and Partners, 2023).

At the same time, local entrepreneurs and community members form the foundation of this transformation. Their active involvement in adaptive reuse projects—such as converting heritage buildings into cafés, boutique hotels, and cultural hubs—helps preserve Songwat’s architectural and historical legacy while stimulating economic renewal. Community-based initiatives like “Made in Songwat” highlight the importance of local participation in urban regeneration and decision-making, ensuring that growth remains sustainable, inclusive, and deeply rooted in the district’s distinctive identity (Suvarnananda, 2024).

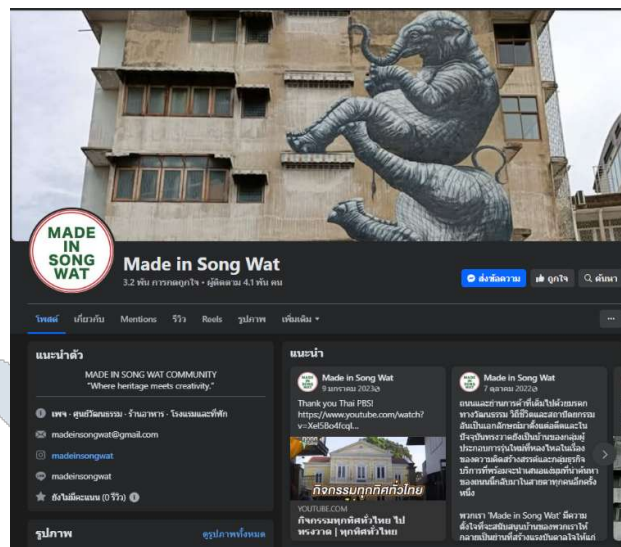


Figure 1.6 : Made in Song Wat’s Facebook page (Photo source : Facebook, 2025)

The beginnings and collaborative steps of Songwat's creative-led regeneration are still unexplored, especially in terms of how various stakeholders—from new creative entrepreneurs to legacy family businesses—engage in finding a balance between modernization and heritage preservation. By examining who started Songwat's creative regeneration and analyzing the connections between key stakeholders, this thesis aims to close these gaps. It focuses on how they build networks of collaboration, promote cultural capital, and work together to create inclusive regeneration strategies. Planners, policymakers, and community members who support sustainable regeneration, heritage preservation, and creative economies will find this information useful.

Essentially, both local actors' grassroots drives and government organization's strategic policy initiatives contributed to Songwat's transformation. The research discusses how both

creativity and tradition collaborate through stakeholder collaboration in shaping Songwat's cultural, economic, and landscape transformation. It provides this by focusing on first-hand experiences and comparative fieldwork.

1.2 Initial Aims

1.2.1 To explore who initiated the creative regeneration in Songwat Old Neighborhood and the background contexts that have influenced this urban transformation.

1.2.2 To understand the key stakeholders and collaborative dynamics involved in Songwat's creative-led regeneration, focusing on how their interactions shape the neighborhood's cultural, economic, and spatial renewal.

1.3 Research Questions

1.3.1 Who initiated Songwat Old Neighborhood's creative regeneration process, and what situations or backgrounds influenced their participation in urban regeneration?

1.3.2 How do various stakeholders collaborate in Songwat's creative-led regeneration, and how do the interactions impact the neighborhood's environment, cultural, and economic development?

Furthermore, these questions guide the research to ensure that every stakeholder, regeneration model, and collaborative practice is carefully considered.

1) Emerging Creative Ventures and Newcomers

- Who are the key entrepreneurs and creative actors now active in Songwat, and how do their backgrounds (family-based or newcomer) shape their roles?
- Why do particular entrepreneurs and creative actors choose to invest in Songwat—whether by reworking family businesses or launching new ventures—and how do their motivations, identities, and resources shape the kinds of regeneration they make possible?
- How do new ventures transform products, services, or business models to balance tradition with innovation?
- What attracts newcomers without family roots to Songwat, and how do their ventures influence local dynamics?
- Through which networks, actors, or community initiatives did these newcomers become involved in Songwat?

2) Governance, Collaboration, and Regeneration Initiatives

- How do BMA and CEA articulate and implement urban zoning, and neighborhood development in Songwat?
- What collaborative models or governance mechanisms exist between public agencies, creative businesses, and local groups for regeneration?
- What are the strengths, challenges, and opportunities of “creative elites-led” creative city-making, and how is community participation achieved in Songwat?
- How do initiative group, such as the Made in Songwat, contribute to Songwat’s urban transformation and local empowerment?

3) Songwat’s Past, Present, and Future

- How have Songwat’s social, economic, and physical environments changed in recent years, according to diverse stakeholders?
- What are stakeholders’ aspirations and visions for Songwat’s future development?
- In what ways has the Made in Songwat initiative benefited individual businesses and the broader Songwat community?

1.4 Contribution of this research

This research makes three contributions to theory, Thai policy and planning context, and practice in historic commercial districts.

- The study refines debates on creative elites by positioning them in a Thai-Chinese urban and social context, rather than the Western cases that dominate the literature. While much of the literature on the "creative class" and creative elites focuses on highly mobile, globally oriented professionals, the Songwat case demonstrates how creative elites in Bangkok are frequently locally rooted through kinship, alumni ties, and inherited shophouses, and move fluidly between roles as entrepreneurs, heirs of family businesses, and cultural brokers. This localized, networked form of elite agency complicates simple binary distinctions between "outsider elites" and "local communities" and demonstrates how elite power can emerge from a combination of inherited assets, professional experience, and dense social networks within a historic neighborhood.
- The research contributes to the discussion on gentrification and creative cities by highlighting a unique type of creative-led regeneration that differs from traditional displacement models. In Songwat, creative elites and new lifestyle businesses significantly increase visibility, land values, and consumption patterns, putting pressure on affordability and everyday livelihoods. However, they do so in a

context where many local residents, long-standing wholesalers, and family business heirs remain physically present and continue to operate, even as their roles and margins change. The thesis therefore supports a more nuanced understanding of “gentrification without full replacement,” where symbolic, economic, and cultural transformations are profound but do not immediately translate into the wholesale expulsion of local people. This contributes to a differentiated view of gentrification in Asian historic districts, where heritage conservation, family ownership, and fragmented shophouse tenure can slow, filter, or reshape classic displacement trajectories.

- The study expands on creative city and placemaking theory by viewing Songwat's regeneration as a distributed urban agency involving creative elites, municipal government (BMA), national intermediary (CEA), and grassroots collectives (Made in Songwat) working together to create change. Rather than seeing creative elites as heroic innovators or one-dimensional agents of neoliberal displacement, the research shows how they act as placemakers, intermediaries, and network brokers, translating policy platforms into local events, mobilizing resources across public and private arenas, and negotiating between heritage, commerce, and community needs. This layered role points toward a more relational, context-sensitive framework for understanding creative-elite-led regeneration—one that recognizes both its regenerative capacities and its uneven, contested impacts on everyday urban life.

Chapter 2

Literature review

2.1 The Creative City

The idea that cities serve as engines of creativity and innovation is not new. As Richard Florida notes, cities have long been seen by sociologists, economists, and urbanists—from Alfred Marshall to Robert Park and Jane Jacobs—as "cauldrons of diversity and difference and as fonts for creativity and innovation"(Florida, 2002, p.3).

The concept of the "creative city" has become center stage in contemporary urban studies, policies, and practices at the beginning of the twenty-first century. It expresses the idea that by encouraging creativity, engaging in brilliant people, and supporting cultural industries, cities may foster economic growth, innovation, and regeneration.

Charles Landry, a key figure in the development of the Creative City concept, observed that successful cities were those that adapted to change by leveraging their cultural assets, fostering innovation, and encouraging new forms of collaboration between the public, private, and voluntary sectors. Landry's early work in the late 1980s and 1990s, particularly in cities like Glasgow and Barcelona, highlighted the importance of visionary leadership, open-mindedness, and a willingness to take risks as essential qualities for urban success(Landry, 2008).

According to the widely known idea of Richard Florida, the "creative class" is the main force behind regional and urban economic expansion. According to Florida (2002) :

"Neighborhoods become successful when they attract and retain people in creative industries, such as scientists, engineers, artists, and knowledge laborers. Florida claims that the existence of this class is associated with higher levels of professional advancement, innovation, and general economic vibrancy. He presents the "3Ts" framework, which stands for Technology, Talent, and Tolerance, as the key components needed to develop innovative neighborhoods. San Francisco, Boston, Austin, and other cities with excellent ratings on these characteristics are recognized as top creative hubs, with strong growth in high-tech businesses and innovation outputs" (Florida,2002, p. 10-11).

By focusing on the particular groups of creative people and the cultural and social variables which attract them, Florida's creative capital theory expands towards but differs from traditional human capital and agglomeration theories. He argues that open, diverse, and tolerant communities are attractive to creative people because they provide them with a sense of identity

validation and allow them to develop interesting careers. By changing the focus from firm-centric incentives to tactics that increase a city's attractiveness to creative talent, this perspective reframes urban policy (Florida, 2002, p.8).

Charles Landry's *The Creative City: A Toolkit for Urban Innovators* (2000) advocates for creative, adaptable, and collaborative methods of urban government. Stemming from a distinct intellectual justification and trajectory, Landry's work establishes the "creative city" as a guideline for urban policy, arguing for a strategy that leverages creativity and culture as instrumental tools for urban regeneration and economic growth.

He introduced the idea of a "creative milieu," as a place—ranging from a cluster of buildings to a whole region—that possesses the necessary preconditions to "generate a flow of ideas and inventions"(Landry, 2008, p.133). His framework emphasizes the importance of embedding a culture of creativity into the "genetic code" of cities, requiring visionary leadership, diverse talent, and an organizational culture that encourages risk-taking and collaboration(Landry, 2008, p.132).

Richard Florida's *The Rise of the Creative Class, Revisited* (2012) further developed the Creative City paradigm by linking urban success to the concentration of creative professionals. Florida's "creative class" includes scientists, engineers, artists, designers, and knowledge workers whose creativity is central to their work(Florida, 2005, p.4). He argues that this class now comprises a significant portion of the workforce in advanced economies and is the primary driver of economic growth and innovation(Florida, 2012, p.9-11).

Despite the widespread popularity, Richard Florida's Creative Class has attracted a lot of criticism from scholars, most notably Andy C. Pratt(2008). Pratt challenges the core concepts of Florida's model in his 2008 analysis, particularly the causal mechanisms it proposes. He raises both conceptual and practical problems, arguing that the connection between the creative class and urban regeneration is far more complex than Florida claims.

Measurement and causality are both of the key issues Pratt identifies. Florida's model claims the relationship between the presence of the creative class and economic growth by relying heavily on indicators like the "3Ts"(Florida, 2012, p.11). However according to Pratt, this approach falls short of proving the existence of a causal relationship. In addition, he criticizes the idea of the creative class as being imprecise and eclectic, which makes it difficult to operationalize and raises questions about the thesis's validity.

Pratt(2008) also criticizes the discourse around creative cities for emphasizing consumption above production. Florida-inspired urban plans frequently emphasize consumption-oriented tactics, including place marketing and the development of cultural

amenities, in an effort to attract creative people. Pratt argues that this overlooks the cultural industries' creative aspect and the significance of supporting the full cycle of cultural creation, from production to distribution and consumption. He argues that labor and infrastructure for cultural creation would be given priority under a more inclusive and sustainable approach.

Pratt and other critics also highlight the negative social effects of creative-led regeneration, specifically gentrification and exclusion. Due to its emphasis on attracting wealthy creative people, the creative city concept may result in the displacement of current populations, such as artists and lower-class citizens. Consumption-based urban strategy might inadvertently undermine the very cultural ecosystems they claim to support, excluding the grassroots creativity that frequently serve as the foundation of vibrant urban culture.

Jamie Peck (2007) provides the creative city agenda in wider neoliberal trends and offers a scathing critique of the "creativity fix" in urban policy. According to Peck, the creative city script is a "soft neoliberal" policy fix that can be easily included into current agendas for market-oriented urban development.

Peck's criticism is on the commercialization of diversity, art, and culture. These components are frequently valued in the discourse of the creative class not because of their intrinsic social or cultural value but rather because of their ability to foster urban competitiveness and economic growth. More critical or community-based perspectives of cultural life become excluded by this instrumental vision, which reduces culture to a means of attracting talent and money.

Peck also criticizes the policy responses that are influenced by the creative city model, which frequently take the form of place marketing that is focused on consumption and leisure. Without addressing more fundamental inequality, these strategies frequently place an emphasis on image-making and cultural spectacle, encouraging gentrification and property-led development. These strategies, far from being revolutionary, sometimes reinforce established geographical and social hierarchies.

Furthermore, the narrative of the creative city usually revolves around the needs and goals of a mobile, highly educated, and powerful creative elite. Other urban residents are so excluded, especially manual and service workers who are consigned to lower positions within the urban economy. This narrow focus undermines the diversity that thriving, truly creative cities need and widens socioeconomic divides (Peck, 2007).

Pratt and other scholars support a more complex view of the relationship of urban economies, culture, and creativity. They support policies that recognize the significance of cultural production as well as the hybrid character of contemporary economies, where

production and consumption, as well as manufacturing and services, are becoming increasingly connected. The creative and cultural industries-encompassing sectors such as media, design, and the arts-are seen as engines of urban growth and innovation in their own right, not merely as tools for attracting talent or tourists(Pratt, 2008).

Landry's toolkit for urban innovators outlines practical strategies for embedding creativity into urban governance and planning. He emphasizes the importance of "soft infrastructure", networks, cultural institutions, and public spaces, alongside traditional "hard infrastructure." Landry advocates for "third spaces", neither home nor work, where people can meet, exchange ideas, and network, as well as for urban design that fosters communication and high levels of amenity(Landry,2008, p. xxii-xxiii).

"The Creative Town Initiative was the first urban strategy project of its kind. The proposal argued that creativity, a latent form of intellectual capital, exists in all walks of life—in business, in education, in public administration, in social care services." (Landry, 2008, p. 80)

Huddersfield, a former industrial town in northern England, launched the Creative Town Initiative (CTI) in 1997 to tackle economic decline. Supported by the EU, CTI aimed to spread creativity across government, business, education, and social services. Projects included creative forums, business training, and spaces like the Kirklees Media Centre.

The initiative helped change Huddersfield's image, bringing creativity into local policy and attracting new businesses and attention. CTI showed that creativity can drive economic and social renewal beyond the arts.

"Cities like Barcelona, Sydney, Seattle, Vancouver, Helsinki, Glasgow, Bangalore, Ahmedabad, Curitiba, Rotterdam, Dublin, the cluster along the Emscher river in the Ruhr in Germany or around Zürich, Karlsruhe, Strasbourg—these and other thriving cities seem to have made economic and social development work for them." (Landry, 2008, p. 3)

Barcelona is often seen as a top example of using creativity for urban regeneration. The city's renewal included major cultural projects, upgrades to public spaces, and global events like the 1992 Olympics. Its strategy combined culture, innovation, and urban design to make the city more lively and appealing.

This approach brought strong economic growth, a better quality of life, and global recognition. Barcelona's success highlights the value of strong leadership, teamwork across sectors, and smart use of cultural assets in city development.

"Cities that are succeeding in the new economy, it appears, are also the most diverse, tolerant and bohemian places. Cities that are investing heavily in high-technology futures but

who are not also providing a broad mix of cultural experiences are going to fall behind in the longer term.” (Florida, 2012, p. 304)

Austin is often highlighted in Richard Florida’s work as a city that attracts and keeps creative professionals. Known for its lively music scene, cultural diversity, and entrepreneurial spirit, Austin embodies Florida’s “3Ts”: Technology, Talent, and Tolerance. The city focused on creating an environment that appeals to creative people, supporting tech and creative industries, and promoting openness.

As a result, Austin grew rapidly, becoming a center for technology and innovation, with a strong reputation for quality of life and vibrant culture.

The concept of the creative city has impacted urban policy and discourse by emphasizing the value of cultural industries, diversity, and creativity in contemporary urban economies. But as critical scholarship demonstrates, achieving the full potential of creative cities requires discarding simplified models instead of more complex, inclusive, and production-focused approaches.

2.2 Placemaking & City Branding

Placemaking is best understood as a collaborative process for shaping public spaces to enhance community life and shared value. What distinguishes it from purely aesthetic urban design is its deep-seated focus on facilitating creative patterns of use and respecting the unique identities that give a location its distinct character (United Nations Human Settlements Programme (UN-Habitat) et al., 2016). Rather than simply designing a space, placemaking is about cultivating a place—a location endowed with meaning, activity, and a sense of belonging for the people who use it.

Understanding the theory developments that support the practice of modern placemaking is important to completely understand it. This section examines the critical shift from traditional, top-down urban redevelopment models to approaches that focus on culture, creativity, and community as the primary drivers of urban growth and regeneration. This conceptual evolution provides the theoretical basis for why cities are increasingly relying on artists, cultural organizations, and local identity to address complex urban issues.

Consequently, a significant critique within the literature targets the instrumental use of culture in urban policy. Many "creative city" strategies are, at their core, instrumental policies that use culture and creativity to achieve specific non-cultural ends, such as boosting property

values or tourism (Pratt, 2008). This approach can inadvertently stifle the very creativity it purports to foster. Genuine creativity, which involves "the capacity to rewrite rules, to be unconventional" (Landry & Bianchini, 1995, as cited in Krueger & Buckingham, 2009, p. 18), is often constrained by the rigid, compartmentalized thinking inherent in instrumental policymaking. These competing theoretical models—one focused on attracting a creative class through consumption, the other on fostering local cultural production—manifest in the varied strategies practitioners now employ to reshape urban space.

Creative placemaking has been transformed into a variety of advantageous uses by building on its foundations of theory. The particular strategies and cooperative models that practitioners apply to use the arts and culture for social inclusion, economic growth, and community revitalization are described in this section. These strategies go beyond abstract theory to provide concrete ways to make public areas lively, interesting, and profitable.

The literature identifies several key strategies and best practices that are essential for successful creative placemaking. These approaches prioritize collaboration, creativity, and a focus on both cultural and economic outcomes.

- **Engage Diverse Stakeholders:** The cornerstone of effective placemaking is the formation of cross-sector partnerships. Successful projects actively involve a wide array of participants—including artists, community members, local government agencies, private developers, and foundations—in the planning and development process to ensure outcomes are inclusive and broadly supported (McCormick et al., 2020).
- **Adaptive Reuse and Repurposing:** A common and powerful strategy involves the transformation of old, uninspiring, or derelict spaces. Former industrial areas, vacant warehouses, and underutilized lots are repurposed into culturally rich and economically thriving places, preserving the physical heritage of a neighborhood while infusing it with new life (McCormick et al., 2020.; Jones & Evans, 2008).
- **Arts and Culture as an Anchor:** Arts and culture are leveraged as a primary tool for promoting equity, fostering community engagement, and catalyzing revitalization. This can range from permanent cultural institutions to temporary "pop-up" installations, which can spark public interest and build momentum for larger, long-term projects (United Nations Human Settlements Programme (UN-Habitat) et al., 2016; McCormick et al., 2020;).

- **Develop a Business Case:** To attract necessary funding, practitioners create a clear business case that demonstrates a project's return on investment (ROI). This involves utilizing a variety of financing tools, including federal and state tax credits, government grants, private foundation support, and special funding mechanisms like Business Improvement Districts (BIDs)(McCormick et al., 2020).

All of these strategies rely heavily on partnership-based models. Contemporary regeneration projects are too complex and expensive to be completed by a single entity. Instead, they need the collaboration of a wide range of actors from both the public and private sectors, each with their own set of resources, expertise, and perspectives (Jones & Evans, 2008).

Examining diverse real-world case studies becomes vital for understanding the practical application and impact of placemaking principles. This section shows how placemaking can take many different forms, ranging from creative-led commercial regeneration in Asia to community-focused projects in North America. These examples demonstrate not only the successes of placemaking, but also the underlying complexities and unique local factors that shape each project.

The transformation of Seongsu in Seoul, South Korea, illustrates a commercially driven, creative-led regeneration in which a former industrial district of handmade shoe workshops has become a global K-fashion and beauty hub, widely dubbed “the Brooklyn of Seoul” (Hong, 2025). This trajectory encapsulates the tension between supporting production-based cultural industries and catering to a consumption-oriented creative class, as industrial heritage and local manufacturing histories are repurposed alongside trendy flagship stores, concept cafés, and pop-up retail aimed at visitors and tourists (Hong, 2025). Seongsu’s steady rise is reflected in sharply increasing subway ridership and foreign tourist spending, demonstrating how entrepreneurial initiative, community cooperation, and municipal support can interact to drive sustained creative-led urban change (Hong, 2025).



Figure 2.1 : Korean fashion brand which became global brand, flagship store located in Seongsu, South Korea (Photo source : author, December 2023)

In Chicago, the Dorchester Art + Housing Collaborative demonstrates how placemaking can foreground equity by transforming a deteriorated public housing complex into a 32-unit mixed-income artist community anchored by an arts center that provides free cultural programming, supporting creativity as an intrinsic community good rather than merely an economic catalyst (McCormick et al., 2020). In Charlotte, the 3.5-mile Rail Trail reimagines a former emergency access path as a linear park linking ten neighborhoods and energizing local businesses, yet its popularity raises concerns about rising property values and the potential displacement of lower-income residents (McCormick et al., 2020). Memphis's Crosstown Concourse similarly showcases large-scale adaptive reuse by converting a 1.2-million-square-foot Sears warehouse into a mixed-use "vertical village," but its scale and investment intensity prompt questions about whether revitalization benefits the surrounding low-income community or risks creating an exclusive enclave (McCormick et al., 2020). Together, these cases highlight placemaking's transformative potential while embodying the very critiques—gentrification, exclusion, and neoliberal instrumentality—that complicate its status as an unambiguously positive urban strategy.



Figure 2.2 : Dorchester Art + Housing Collaborative (Photo source : Chicago Women in Architecture, n.d.)

The advantages of placemaking must be balanced against important criticisms regarding power and equity. It is often associated with gentrification, in which improvements to the neighborhood's aesthetics and culture draw in higher-class users, increase the value of the land, and drive out lower-class inhabitants and small businesses that initially defined its character (UN-Habitat, n.d.).

Additionally, MacLeod (2002), as cited in Jones & Evans (2008), demonstrates how regeneration may break down urban space, creating refined neighborhoods that primarily serve wealthy tourists while excluding minorities through policing, monitoring, and privatized management. In this context, culture is frequently used as a branding tool in neoliberal urbanism, valued more for its ability to draw in capital than for its inherent social and political significance (Dávila, 2014).

Community participation is frequently cited as a safeguard, but Charles Landry's (2008) scale of creative empowerment warns that many initiatives remain at the levels of "co-option" or "consultation," where residents provide opinions but outsiders retain the power to decide the course of action. These dynamics highlight a fundamental tension between placemaking as an instrumental driver of urban competitiveness and as a truly inclusive practice, where the focus on economic development can narrow the definition of worthy cultural investments and legitimate creative workers (Dávila, 2014).

Placemaking is presented in the literature as a powerful but deeply contested strategy for modern urban development, celebrated for creating vibrant, culturally rich, and economically dynamic places while also being criticized for fueling gentrification, social exclusion, and cultural commodification (Dávila, 2014; Jones & Evans, 2008). These dualities demonstrate that, without a deliberate equity focus, placemaking has the potential to break down communities and displace vulnerable groups as well as strengthen local identity and economies (Dávila, 2014; Jones & Evans, 2008).

2.3 Creative-Elite and Urban Regeneration in Thai Social Context

Urban regeneration is increasingly shaped by the expansion of the creative economy, where ideas, expertise, and cultural production are treated as key drivers of urban competitiveness and growth (Florida, 2002; Pratt, 2008). This shift requires rethinking not only how cities develop but also who is empowered to decide what forms of regeneration are pursued and whose interests are prioritized in the process (Evans, 2009). In this context, the notion of *creative elites* becomes central, especially in Thailand, where long-standing elite networks, patron–client relations, and family-based business structures continue to play a major role in shaping urban decision-making and access to resources.

Sociologically, elites are commonly defined as small groups of people who exercise disproportionate power and influence by occupying top positions within a society's major institutions (Higley, 2024). In the Thai context, this broad category includes interconnected networks of high-ranking state officials, military leaders, big-business families, and local power brokers, whose influence is reproduced through family ties, patron–client relations, and privileged access to state resources (Gliniak, 2021). Rather than operating as isolated individuals, these elites function through dense social and institutional networks that shape how public resources are allocated, which development projects move forward, and how urban land and heritage are used.

Within this wider constellation of Thai elites, *creative elites* can be understood as actors who hold significant power over cultural production and the symbolic framing of urban change. They include designers, curators, cultural entrepreneurs, media figures, and owners of influential venues who help define which places, practices, and aesthetics are recognized as valuable, “authentic,” and worthy of investment. Their power rests not only on economic capital but also on cultural and social capital: the capacity to brand neighborhoods, attract attention and visitors, mobilize collaborations, and position specific districts as creative or heritage destinations (Pratt, 2008). In many Western debates on the “creative class,” such elites

are often portrayed as mobile, cosmopolitan professionals whose lifestyles and preferences drive gentrification and the reinvention of former industrial or working-class neighborhoods (Florida, 2002).

In Thai urban settings such as Songwat, however, creative elites do not simply appear as external newcomers or anonymous global professionals. Many of the key creative actors involved in Songwat's regeneration are locally embedded and socially connected, rather than transient outsiders. They include second- or third-generation heirs of Chinese–Thai family businesses, entrepreneurs who own or inherit shophouses, alumni of the same elite schools, and cultural workers with long-standing ties to the neighborhood. Their elite status thus emerges from a combination of professional experience in creative industries, access to capital, and deep-rooted connections to local commercial and social networks that are characteristic of Thai patron–client and family-based systems.

In Thai urban settings such as Songwat, however, creative elites do not simply appear as external newcomers or anonymous global professionals. Many of the key creative actors involved in Songwat's regeneration are locally embedded and socially connected, rather than transient outsiders. They include second- or third-generation heirs of Chinese–Thai family businesses, entrepreneurs who own or inherit shophouses, alumni of the same elite schools, and cultural workers with long-standing ties to the neighborhood. Their elite status emerges from a combination of professional experience in creative and service industries, access to inherited capital and property linked to Thai–Chinese business families, and their positions within enduring patron–client and family-based networks that structure Thai economic and urban life (Bertrand et al., 2008; Luechapattanaorn & Wongsurawat, 2021; Malaithong, 2024)

Songwat case exemplifies a distinct type of creative elite-led regeneration in which creative elites serve as both drivers of change and preservers of continuity, reshaping the material and symbolic landscape while remaining rooted in and benefiting from built Thai style networks.

Chapter 3

Methodology

3.1 Research Design

Songwat was chosen as the research location because of its long history as a hub of Chinese-Thai family businesses and its ongoing transformation within Bangkok's creative and entrepreneurial landscape. The study uses targeted sampling to identify key entrepreneurs and creative actors involved in the area's regeneration, including local business owners, artists, and creative professionals with both long-term and newcomer ties, as well as officials from the Bangkok Metropolitan Administration (BMA) and the Creative Economy Agency (CEA), whose policy frameworks and programs support and amplify regeneration efforts. This strategy encourages a thorough examination of how various forms of creative capital, professional backgrounds, social networks, and government interventions contribute to the transformation of Songwat's historic urban fabric.



Figure 3.1 : Traditional Wholesale Business in Songwat (Photo Source :
urbancreature, 2024)

This study uses a qualitative, single-case study design to examine how social networks, shared professional experiences, and interpersonal relationships among local entrepreneurs, government officials, and creative actors influence their ability to collaborate in Songwat. The complexity and contextual specificity of these cooperative practices within a historically significant, culturally rich urban neighborhood are best captured using the case study method (Denscombe, 2014, pp. 4, 56–57). In line with an interpretivist approach, this design helps

develop a deep understanding of how trust, familiarity, and informal ties are built, sustained, and used to make joint projects possible, bringing out participants' beliefs, meanings, and lived experiences through qualitative data (Denscombe, 2014, p. 2).

Songwat provides a particularly rich setting for studying how creative elites collaborate with public-sector actors in a specific historical and cultural context, as the neighborhood's socio-spatial characteristics highlight how relational dynamics and place-based meanings shape cooperation between these creative and governmental actors. There are three main reasons why Songwat's case is significant and interesting:

- It is a historic trading district in transition, with Sino-Thai shophouses and commercial heritage coexisting with a variety of cafés, galleries, and creative businesses.
- It has dense, overlapping networks of family business owners, young creative entrepreneurs, and multi-level government and non-government actors.
- It is subject to competing narratives of value—as a heritage landscape, a logistics corridor, and a developing creative district—resulting in challenges and collaborations between conservation, commerce, and creativity in everyday practice.

3.2 Data Collection Methods

Firstly, this study will employ both semi-structured and unstructured interviews. Semi-structured interviews use a clear list of issues and questions, while allowing flexibility in the order of topics and giving interviewees space to develop their ideas and speak more broadly around the themes raised; answers are open-ended, with emphasis on encouraging elaboration on points that participants find important (Denscombe, 2014, p. 186). Unstructured interviews place even greater emphasis on interviewees' own thoughts and perspectives: the interviewer introduces only a broad theme or topic and then adopts a largely non-directive role, allowing participants to pursue their own lines of thought rather than following a predefined question schedule (Denscombe, 2014, pp. 186–187).

In this study, semi-structured interviews will be conducted with founders and current leaders of the Made in Songwat collective, creative entrepreneurs, next-generation business successors, non-family managers, and key representatives from the BMA and the CEA, enabling the research to capture multiple perspectives on how creative initiatives, policy frameworks, and everyday business practices intersect in Songwat's regeneration. Unstructured interviews will also be carried out with shopowners and visitors in Songwat to elicit more open, grounded accounts of everyday experiences and perceptions of change in the neighborhood.

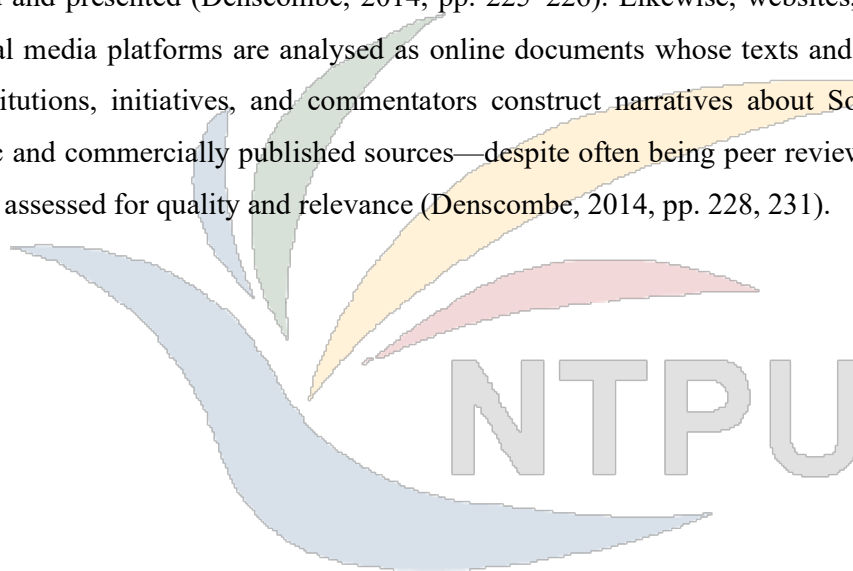
No.	Group of Interviewees	Shop/Organization		Role	Date of Interview	Group
1	Key Members of Made in Songwat (Semi-structure)	Gallery	Mr. A	Owner	30/9/2025	businesses using inherited buildings for different trades
2		Hostel	Miss F	manager	27/9/2025	businesses using inherited buildings for different trades
3		Tea Shop	Mr. K	Owner	23/10/2025	new businesses by newcomers
4		Thai Dessert Cafe	Miss G	Owner	10/10/2025	new businesses by newcomers
5	Entrepreneurs (Semi-structure)	Traditional Wholesale	Miss T	Owner	29/9/2025	long-established family businesses
6		Agar(jelly) Restaurant	Miss P	Owner	26/9/2025	new ventures built on family legacy
7		Cafe and Hotel	Mr. M	Owner	27/9/2025	new businesses by newcomers
8		Cafe and BNB	Miss J	Owner	27/9/2025	new businesses by newcomers
9		Design studio& Cafe	Miss B	Owner	28/9/2025	new businesses by newcomers
10		Thai style specialty cafe	Miss D	manager	29/9/2025	new businesses by newcomers
11		Chinese-Thai restaurant	Mr. C	Owner	29/9/2025	new businesses by newcomers
12		Japanese Cafe	Miss I	Owner	1/10/2025	new businesses by newcomers
13	Unstructured	Traditional Wholesale	Miss N	Owner	30/9/2025	Traditional shop owner

14	Interview	Shopowner	Miss S	Owner	11/8/2025	Shopowner
15		Visitor	Miss R	-	28/1/2025	Tourist
16		Visitor	Miss W	-	11/8/2025	Tourist
17		Visitor	Mr. O	-	19/8/2025	Tourist
18	Public Sector (Semi-structure)	BMA	Miss E	Director	29/9/2025	Government staff
19		CEA	Miss H	Former Director	19/10/2025	Government staff
20		BMA	Mr. L	Deputy	20/8/2025	Government staff

Table 3.1 : List of interviewees in this research

Secondly, government and organizational documents, local social media, and related online sources will be reviewed to situate entrepreneurial activities in Songwat within broader urban and historical developments. These materials are treated as primary data within a documentary research strategy, which understands written, digital, and visual documents—such as plans, reports, websites, and social media posts—as records that not only provide information but also embody deeper meanings, structures, and values that can be interpreted rather than taken at face value (Denscombe, 2014, pp. 225–228).

Government publications and official statistics are especially useful because they offer relatively stable records of policy priorities and development trajectories, although their apparent authority and objectivity must still be critically examined in terms of how the data are produced and presented (Denscombe, 2014, pp. 225–226). Likewise, websites, home pages, and social media platforms are analysed as online documents whose texts and images show how institutions, initiatives, and commentators construct narratives about Songwat, while academic and commercially published sources—despite often being peer reviewed—must be carefully assessed for quality and relevance (Denscombe, 2014, pp. 228, 231).



Organization/ Platform	Details	Questions
BMA	20 year - BKK development plan	How is Songwat positioned within Bangkok's long-term vision for historic districts and creative economy development?
CEA	CEA official website	How does CEA frame Songwat within national and city-level creative economy and creative district policies?
	CEA Annual report	
Made in Songwat	Songwat guidebook	How do local creative actors narrate Songwat's history, identity, and future as a creative/heritage district?
	Song Wat guidebook #2	
Facebook	Made in Songwat	How is Songwat's regeneration communicated and branded to the public and potential visitors online?
Instagram	@madeinsongwat	What kinds of visual narratives and everyday practices are highlighted to construct Songwat's creative image
Website	Urbancreature	How do media and cultural writers describe Songwat's transformation and the role of creative actors?

Table 3.2 : Key documentary and online sources for understanding Songwat's regeneration

Lastly, this study will use participant observation by attending community events and relevant forums in Songwat to observe real-time interactions, business practices, and forms of community engagement, thereby providing additional contextual depth to the interview data. Participant observation is an unobtrusive method that places the researcher in the daily life of the people under study—observing what happens, listening to what is said, and informally questioning participants over a period of time—in order to understand lifestyles, cultures, and

beliefs as they unfold in their natural setting (Becker & Geer, 1957, as cited in Denscombe, 2014, p. 215). This approach is especially useful because it offers insights into everyday social situations that people might find hard to explain in an interview, and it helps reduce their hesitation to talk about sensitive or taken-for-granted parts of their lives (Denscombe, 2014, pp. 205, 215, 217).

Type of observation	Event's name	Date	Questions
Major event	Awakening 2025	8-17 August 2025	How does the atmosphere change during major creative events, and what kinds of activities and visitors are attracted to Songwat?
Public speech	Taiwan Excellent Commercial District Award and International Exchange Forum 2025	31 October 2025	How do local creative elites publicly describe Songwat's regeneration, and what networks and visibility can be generated through this forums?
Field Observation	● Weekdays - Day time - Evening - Night time ● Weekends - Day time - Evening - Night time	27 September - 1 October 2025	How does street life differ between weekdays and weekends, and which groups of visitors or users are present on each day?

Table 3.3 : List of Observations

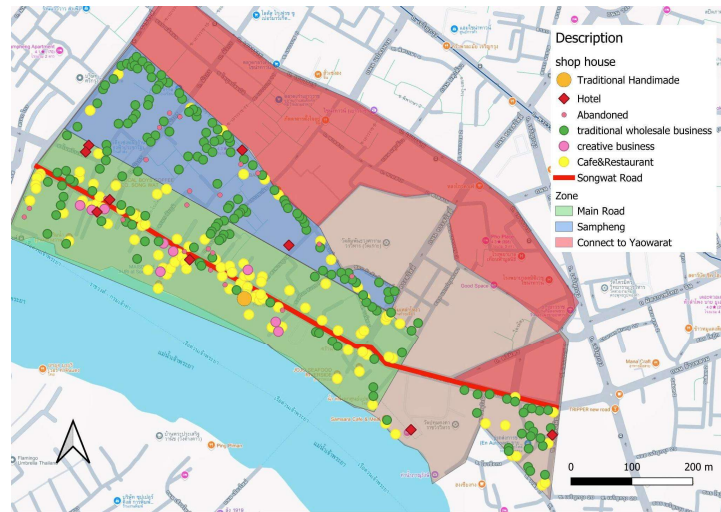


Figure 3.2 : Main field observation area in the research, covering area along Songwat road. (Photo source : Author, 2025)



Figure 3.3 : Neighborhood map illustrating the "Sights" and "Tastes" of Songwat. (Photo Source : urbancreature, 2024)

3.3 Data Analysis

Denscombe notes, “The data should be catalogued and indexed. Each piece of ‘raw data’ should be identified with a unique serial number for reference purposes. The importance of this is that when analyzing the data it is vital that the researcher is able to return to points in the data which are of particular interest. Without an adequate reference system it will be virtually impossible for the researcher to navigate back and forth through the data or to record which bits of data are significant(Denscombe, 2014, p. 277).

The study will use a qualitative thematic analysis to interpret interview transcripts, observation notes, and documentary materials in relation to creative-elite-led regeneration in Songwat. All interviews will be audio-recorded (with consent), transcribed, and read repeatedly to gain familiarity with participants' accounts of collaboration, regeneration practices, and perceptions of change.

Where possible, findings will be compared across different family businesses to identify similarities and differences in the transmission of entrepreneurial legacy and adaptation strategies.

An initial round of open coding will be used to pick out short, meaningful segments in the data that relate to themes such as elite networks, cooperation with BMA and CEA, placemaking, heritage reuse, and the benefits or problems of regeneration. Both deductive (theory-led) and inductive (data-led) coding will be used so that the analysis can capture repeated patterns as well as new, unexpected ideas, with all material organised in a simple reference system. The codes will then be merged into broader themes and compared across different groups of participants, including creative entrepreneurs, Made in Songwat members, municipal officers, and CEA staff.

Observation notes from community events, weekdays and weekends, and major festivals such as Awakening Songwat will be analyzed alongside interview material to trace how interactions, visitor patterns, and uses of space correspond to respondents' narratives. Documentary sources, including BMA's 20-year development plan, CEA policy materials, media reports, and relevant awards or rankings, will be examined to situate local practices within broader policy discourses and representations of Songwat as a creative-heritage district. Throughout the analysis, data sources will be constantly compared to identify intersections and conflicts, allowing the study to connect micro-level relationships and everyday practices with upper-level responsibilities in organizations and macro-level urban transformations, explaining how creative elites, government agencies, and local networks collaborate to produce regeneration in Songwat.

Chapter 4

The Transformation of Songwat

4.1 Songwat's Lasting History: From Royal Initiative to Modern Regeneration

Songwat Road is located in the Samphanthawong district of Bangkok. Songwat Road is a narrow 1.2 kilometers corridor running parallel to the Chao Phraya River, intersecting the historic Chinatown (1) vicinity and lining up with the city's key riverside heritage zone. Although modest in scale, Songwat has historically served as a crucial interface between maritime trade routes and Bangkok's inland commercial networks, beginning near Wat Traimit (2) and stretching past Talad Noi (3) toward old river warehouses and jetties as illustrated in Figure 4.1. The district's dense shophouse blocks, alleyways, and proximity to religious and commercial landmarks reflect its foundational role in more than a century of the city's economic, cultural, and spatial transformation.

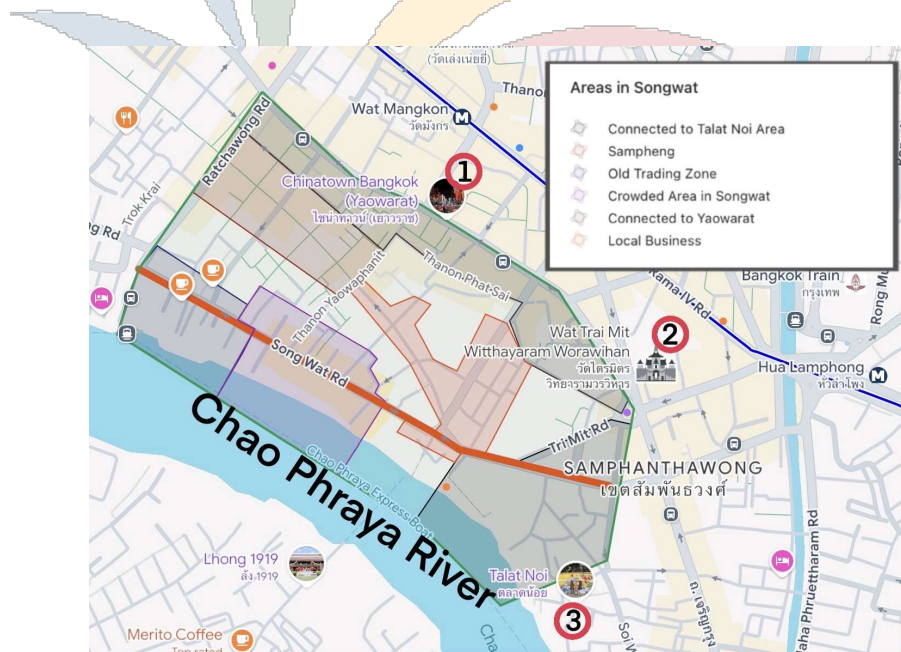


Figure 4.1 : Map of the Songwat area and its geographical boundaries (Photo source : Google map, 2025 adapted by author)

The origins of Songwat date to the reign of King Chulalongkorn (1868-1910), who oversaw sweeping reforms to modernise Siam's administration, economy, and urban environment. Between 1906 and 1907, Songwat Road was constructed following a catastrophic fire in the dense wooden settlements of Sampheng. The new road was envisioned both as a firebreak and as an ordered commercial corridor that would rationalise circulation in Chinatown's growing mercantile district (Ngawtrakun, 2008, pp. 31, 78).

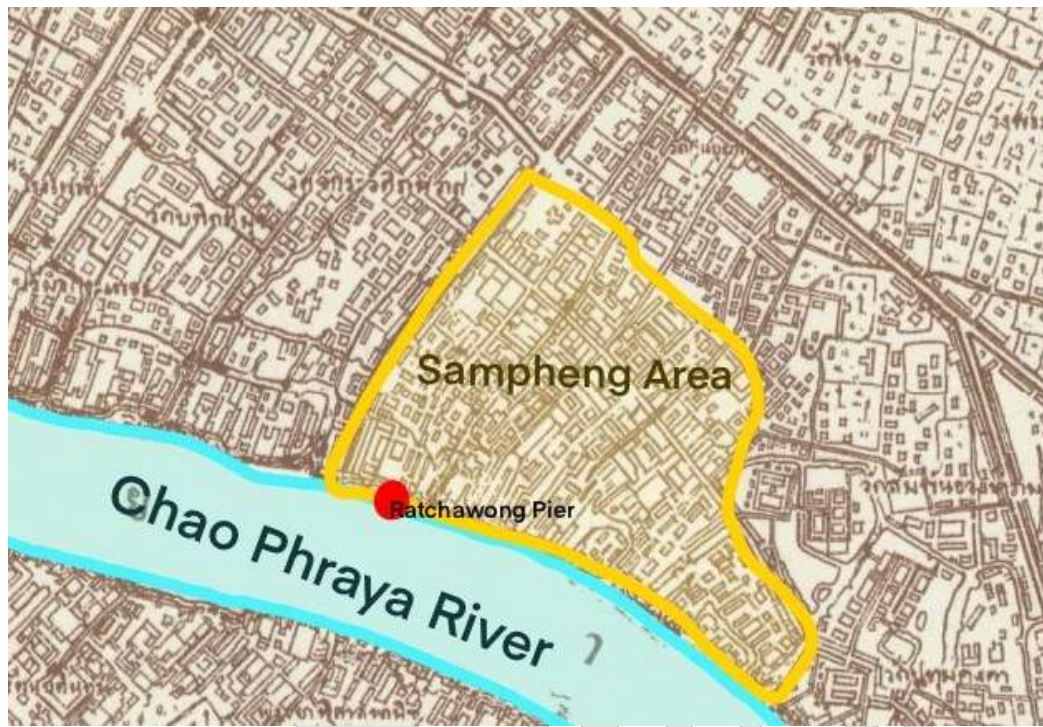


Figure 4.2 : Sampheng area in 1896 before the construction of Songwat Road (Photo source : Royal Thai Survey Department, 2007 adapted by author)

In a gesture that symbolised monarchical authority over urban space, King Chulalongkorn personally drew the alignment of the street on a map, giving rise to its name “Songwat” meaning “drawn by the monarch” (Mekloy, 2020). This act linked Songwat to a broader strategy of infrastructural modernization, which also included Yaowarat, Ratchawong, and Chakkrawat Roads. These new arteries improved circulation, enhanced fire safety, and integrated the district more effectively into Bangkok's expanding commercial landscape.

In terms of geographical location, Songwat is located in the heart of Samphanthawong District, which is home to Bangkok's Chinese business community. Songwat, which ran parallel to the Chao Phraya River and connected directly to Ratchawong Pier, served as an

important transport between inland distribution and maritime trade (Triamvithaya et al., 2021). Products such as rice, spices, pepper, dried fruits, and coconut oil moved through its shophouses and warehouses toward domestic and international markets (Ngawtrakun, 2008, pp. 31, 49). The logistical needs of early twentieth-century shipping were reflected in the deep, narrow plots of its shophouses, which were placed parallel to the river and allowed for quick transfers from ships to warehouses to shops.

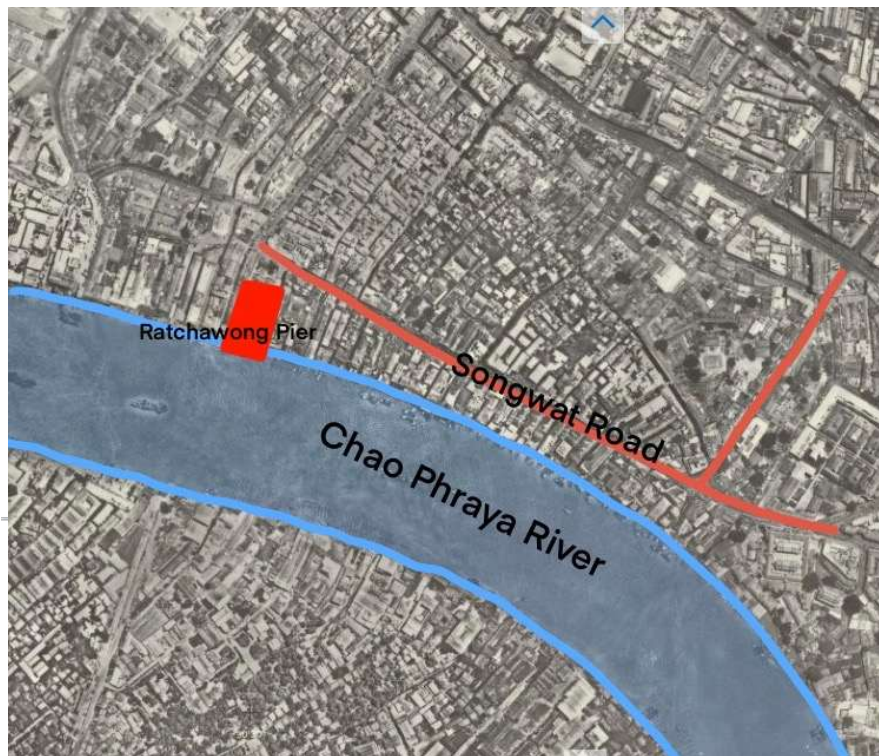


Figure 4.3, Songwat Area from Bangkok-Thonburi City Planning Project (Photo source :Royal Thai Survey Dept., 1958 adapted by Author)

Following the Bowring Treaty of 1855, Siam's increasing integration into international markets correlated with these developments. Songwat became one of the city's busiest commercial districts as exports increased, drawing enterprising immigrants from southern China and integrating itself into the socioeconomic networks of the Thai-Chinese diaspora (Bunnag, 2004).

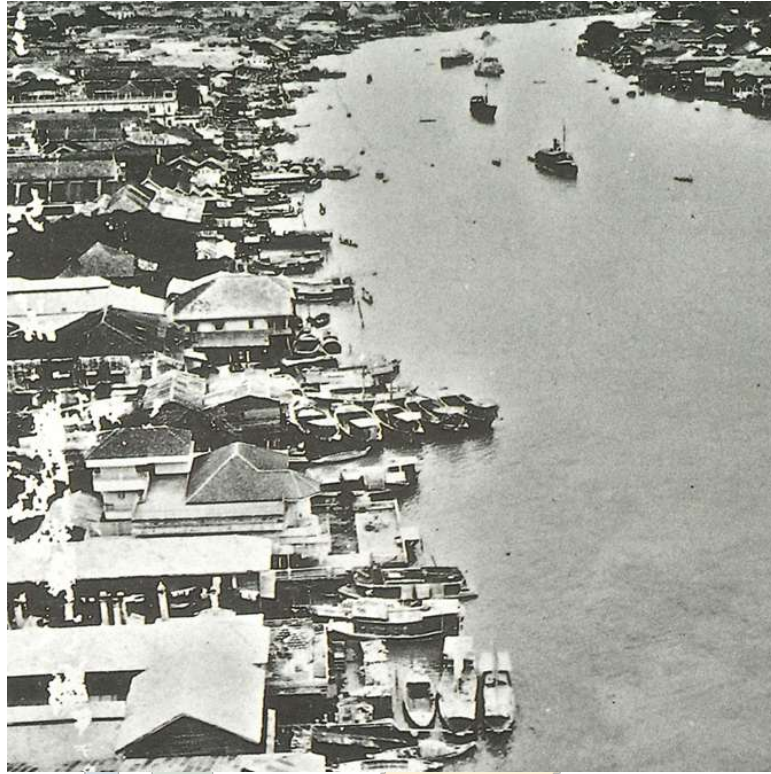


Figure 4.4 : Ratchawong Pier in 1946, taken by Peter Williams-Hunt (Photo source :the National Archive, 1996)

Songwat's early success serves as an example of basic ideas later expressed by Jacobs (1969) and Lucas (1988): dynamic urban economies thrive when a variety of actors, skills, and social networks are concentrated in close proximity. Songwat showed how populated, multicultural commercial neighborhoods can become sources for creative activity and economic transformation long before modern urban theory popularized the concept of creativity-driven districts.

Songwat's architectural landscape is a reflection of both its multicultural visions and its commercial heritage. Its shophouses combined European neoclassical ornamentation, such as pediments, stucco reliefs, arched windows, and pilasters, with Chinese structural forms, such as load-bearing masonry, timber beams, and ceramic tiles (Ngawtrakun, 2008, p. 68). Songwat's connections to local multinational networks are demonstrated by this unique style, which is similar to developments in Penang, Malacca, and Singapore (Silpa-mag, 2021a; Mekloy, 2020).

One famous example is the "Fruit Building,"(Figure4.5) whose façades have stucco designs of pineapples, durians, and mangosteens. These specifics represented the merchants' international cultural ties as well as the nature of their trade.



Figure 4.5: Fruit Building (Photo source: author, August 2025)

The district's architectural diversity matched its institutional diversity. Buddhist, Chinese, and Muslim communities were supported by religious sites such as Wat Samphanthawong (Figure 4.7), Lao Pun Thao Kong Shrine (Figure 4.8), and the Luang Kocha Itsahak Mosque (Figure 4.9). Distinctive Tuek Khaek Building or "Indian-style" shophouses (Figure 4.10), built by South Asian merchants, further reflected the neighborhood's cosmopolitan trading heritage through their ornate facades and hybrid architectural forms. By offering instruction in Chinese, schools like Peiying School (Figure 4.11) promoted cultural continuity. These institutions worked together to create a complex socio-cultural ecosystem that influenced daily life and served as a foundation for multicultural community identities.



Figure 4.6 : Map shows architectural diversity in Songwat (Photo source : Google Map, 2025 adapted by author)

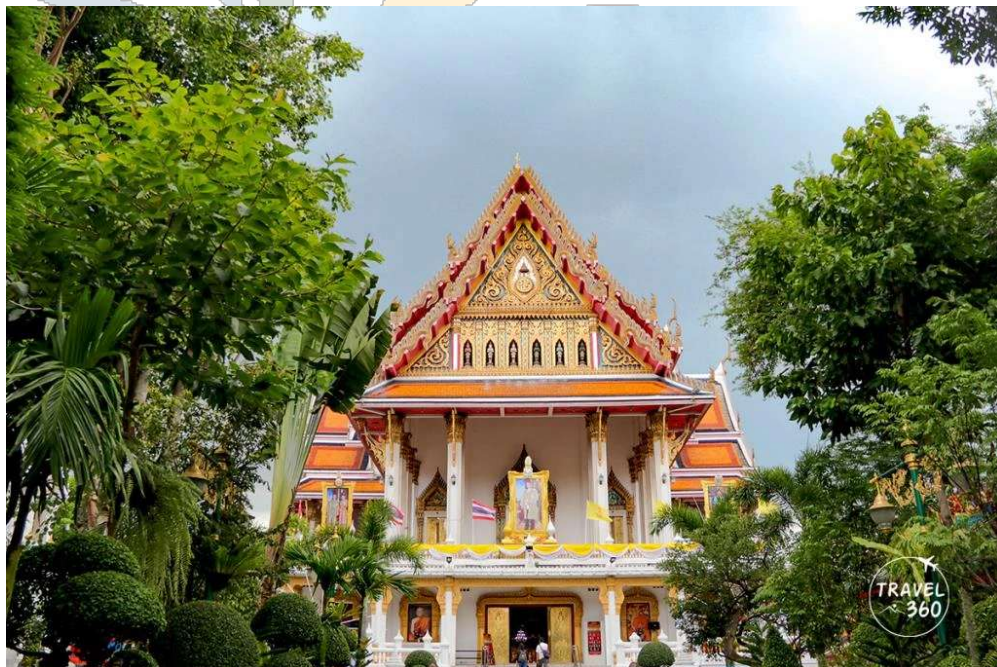


Figure 4.7 : Wat Samphanthawong (Photo source : MGR online, 2023)



Figure 4.8 : Lao Pun Thao Kong Shrine (Photo source : MGR online, 2023)



Figure 4.9 : Luang Kocha Itsahak Mosque (Photo source : MGR online, 2023)



Figure 4.10 : Tuck Khaek Building (Photo source : Urban Creature, 2021)



Figure 4.11 : Peiying school (Photo source : MGR online, 2023)

During this time, Songwat served as an example of Bangkok's multicultural urban development as well as being a commercial center.

By the middle of the 20th century, Sampheng–Songwat avenue had developed into one of Bangkok's most significant wholesale districts. Family businesses operated large local supply networks from their shophouses, which transformed as storefronts, warehouses, and family homes. In addition to maintaining Sampheng's economic vitality, this commercial intensity laid the groundwork for several of Thailand's largest business conglomerates. Notably, the early founders of CP Group, Bangkok Bank, and Saha Pathanapibul used the Songwat–Sampheng region as a beginning point for national expansion, taking advantage of the district's beneficial riverside connections and vast mercantile networks (Mekloy, 2020). Sampheng's historical role as a center of entrepreneurial growth highlights its enduring significance and calls attention to the current problems as the district is under pressure to change and decline.



Figure 4.12 : Map of the largest business conglomerates. located in Songwat (Photo source : Google Map, 2025 adapted by Author)

Name	Estimated Wealth / Market Cap (2025)	Key Notes
CP Group (Chearavanont)	\$44.5 billion family net worth	Thailand's largest conglomerate
Bangkok Bank (Sophonpanich)	\$17.7 billion net assets ; \$8.5B market cap	Largest Thai bank by assets
Saha Pathanapibul	19B THB (c. \$530M) market cap ; Profitable FMCG leader	Major local distributor

Table 4.1 : Table of major Songwat-origin business groups and their 2025 estimated wealth, and sectoral roles (Nation Thailand, 2024; CompaniesMarketCap, 2024; Forbes, 2025, as cited in toutelathailande.fr, 2025; StockAnalysis, 2025; Reuters, 2025).

Songwat's long-lasting commercial success can be explained as the result of structural dynamics that reinforce each other. The first pillar was migration movements: the early concentration of labor and resources in trading businesses was made by the arrival of Chinese entrepreneurs, many of whom were freed from the restrictions of corvée labor (Bunnag, 2004). This resulted in a fundamental economic advantage. The second pillar was kinship. The district's extensive knowledge networks strengthened this advantage as market information, risk assessment techniques, and business practices were shared through kinship-based and intergenerational channels, lowering transaction costs and enhancing the district's capacity to adapt to market volatility. The third factor was location: Songwat's clustering of specialised traders constituted an early form of urban agglomeration, generating productivity gains typical of diverse, skill-intensive urban economies. The complex relationship of these three forces—knowledge circulation, entrepreneurial migration, and spatial clustering—positioned Songwat as a vital commercial engine in Bangkok's urban economy, shaped by local river and canal networks but deeply ingrained in larger international trading circuits.

4.2 The Decline of Songwat

Songwat's main businesses were historically anchored in agricultural and spice wholesaling, operated through dense rows of shophouse-warehouses that lined Songwat Road and connected directly to the Chao Phraya River (Suvarnananda, 2020, pp. 43–45). This spatial logic embedded the district into regional trading networks: goods from upcountry and overseas entered via river piers, were stored and combined in shophouses, and then redistributed to markets across Bangkok and other provinces, making the street a crucial node in Thailand's pre- and early-industrial distribution system (Koktail Magazine, 2023; The Nation, 2024).

Songwat's decline is tightly linked to its spatial fixity. After the Sampheng fire, the street was created along the river and constructed out according to late nineteenth-early twentieth century regulations, with narrow roads, small spaces, and continuous shophouse frontages optimized for pedestrian and cart-based movement rather than high-volume truck traffic (Suvarnananda, 2020, pp. 49–51). Unlike later industrial estates or logistics parks developed on Bangkok's periphery, widening the street, incorporating turning bays, or developing off-street loading docks were impractical options because they would have necessitated extensive expropriation of the densely situated properties. (Ngawtrakun, 2008, p.49).



Figure 4.13 : The figure illustrates the narrow and tightly bounded configuration of Songwat Road in 1967. (Photo source :Heinz Baumann, 1967)

Songwat's location in inner Bangkok led to this lack of flexibility. Surrounded by other historic districts such as Yaowarat and Sampheng, land parcels were already intensely subdivided and built up by the early twentieth century, leaving little residual space for infrastructural expansion (The Nation, 2024). As Bangkok expanded outwards, new growth corridors along major roads and ring roads attracted warehouses and distribution hubs, while Songwat remained essentially locked into its original scale and street pattern, “over-urbanised” in terms of density but under-equipped for modern freight requirements (Hanaoka, 2007).

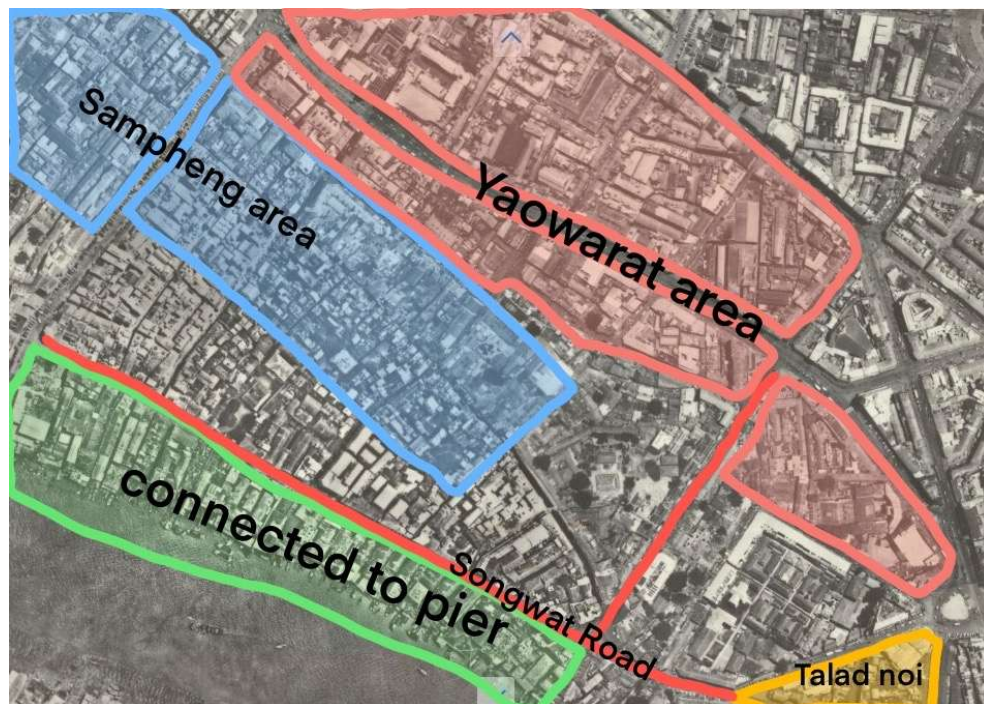


Figure 4.14 : Spatial relationship between Songwat Road (Photo source : Royal Thai Survey Dept., 1958 adapted by Author)

Figure 4.14 illustrates that Songwat's position in Bangkok's dense inner-city fabric severely constrained possibilities for spatial modification. Surrounded by historic districts such as Yaowarat and Sampheng, the area was already tightly developed and subdivided into small parcels, leaving virtually no space for later expansion or physical reconfiguration.

Inner-Bangkok transport policy further reinforced Songwat's logistical disadvantages. In response to chronic congestion, planners and traffic authorities adopted a combination of regulatory and infrastructural measures: large-scale road building (including expressways and ring roads), traffic management schemes, and restrictions on truck access to the central city

(Hanaoka, 2007). These truck-control measures, introduced in the early 2000s, which included partial bans on large trucks in specific zones and time-of-day limitations for heavy vehicles, had citywide goals but uneven spatial effects. Districts like Songwat, whose economic model was based on constant, high-volume flows of goods by truck, were impacted significantly when vehicles could only enter during limited windows or not at all, whereas Bangkok's suburb hubs remained accessible and appealing to logistics operators (Hanaoka, 2007; Ngawtrakun, 2008).

The change in Bangkok's transportation system also represented a more significant shift from an urban economic geography based on water to a system based on roads. Songwat's previous competitive advantage was based on immediate access to river piers and canals, with shophouses serving as a plug-in node connecting the waterborne network to the city (Koktail Magazine, 2023; Ngawtrakun, 2008). Songwat's riverfront location lost value in comparison to inland locations close to expressways and logistical corridors as river-based transportation became less significant and freight shifted to roads and highways. The inability to accommodate modern trucks in both physical and regulatory terms thus gradually eroded the district's centrality within Bangkok's evolving circulation systems (Hanaoka, 2007; Ngawtrakun, 2008; Triamvithaya, et al., 2021).

Parallel to a national development trajectory focused on road-based transport infrastructure (Rujopakarn, 2003), Traditional inner-city wholesale hubs, like Songwat's riverfront commercial district, have been directly impacted by a significant shift in Thailand's retail and distribution industry (Ngawtrakun, 2008). Beginning in the 1990s, this prioritization of road networks facilitated the rapid expansion of modern trade formats, including hypermarkets, large supermarkets, and extensive convenience-store chains, particularly into non-central urban and rural market town locations (Friel et al., 2013; Meeyai, 2018). According to studies on the nation's food retail transition, these corporate formats replaced the dispersed, inner-city wholesale market system by capturing a growing amount of sales and rearranging supply chains around centralized distribution centers linked to national highway networks (Friel et al., 2013; Meeyai, 2018). At the same time, the concentration of modern retailers in convenient suburbs produced a cumulative attraction that increased competition for traditional, smaller wholesalers (Meeyai, 2018). For a historic district like Songwat, this shift progressively affected long-standing social networks that connected vendors with local grocery stores and market traders (Friel et al., 2013). As a result, consumers who had previously traveled to inner Bangkok to purchase goods directly from Songwat merchants increasingly turned to

contemporary distribution platforms, wiping out the customer base that had supported the neighborhood's wholesale economy for many years (Ngawtrakun, 2008).

The combination of space limitations, regulatory vehicle restrictions, and consumer change resulted in obvious social and economic effects on Songwat's business community. Local observations and field-based research show decreased daily turnover, reduced working hours, and more challenges in transferring businesses to younger generations, who frequently see better opportunities in other industries or regions (Suvarnananda, 2020, pp.59-75). Some shophouses became abandoned or unoccupied over time, while others shifted from wholesale to retailing-oriented or niche activities, such as specialty ingredients, small-scale food production, or services aimed at tourists and newer urban consumers (TTR Weekly, 2024; Koktail Magazine, 2023).

The neighborhood's everyday social life was also reshaped by these shifts. In the past, Songwat was rooted in strong networks of kinship and trust among Thai-Chinese families, many of whom operated several nearby businesses and shared common cultural institutions such as temples and clan associations (The Nation, 2024). As some families diversified geographically or moved into other sectors, these once-dense local networks gradually loosened, even as a core group of legacy traders maintained traditional practices such as early-morning wholesale activity and merit-making or donations at Chinese shrines linked to commerce (Suvarnananda, 2020, pp. 56–60). The decline of wholesale trade thus contributed to a partial erosion of the everyday social behaviours that had long defined Songwat's identity.

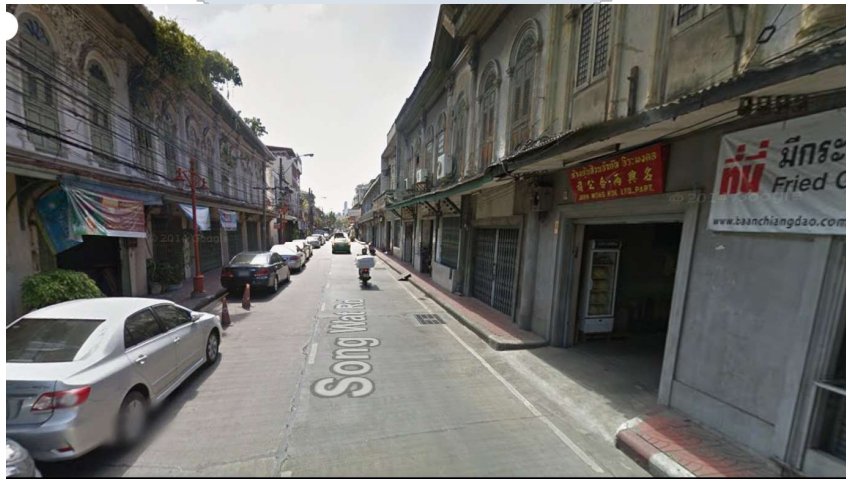


Figure 4.15 : Songwat in 2014. (Photo source : Google Street View (360°), 2014)



Figure 4.16 : Songwat area in 2021 during the COVID-19 pandemic (Photo source : YouTube (VNP Story), 2014)

Preservation through decline and the opening for regeneration

The decline of Songwat's wholesale economy resulted in unoccupied warehouses and shophouses, which helped preserve the city's historic streetscape. The conservation planning for Bangkok's historic core and recognition of Songwat's heritage value limited the current trend for large-scale deconstruction and high-rise redevelopment (Suvarnananda, 2020, pp. 60-62). The street has an obviously continuous historic vibe because many of Songwat's historic shophouses, with their detailed woodwork, stucco decoration, and other historical details, still stand (TTR Weekly, 2024).

Songwat's heritage-inspired creative and tourism destination relies heavily on its surviving fabric. The area's narrow roads, riverfront location, and historic shophouses are what attract local business owners and tourists, according to media and business accounts (Koktail Magazine, 2023; Nikkei Asia, 2025). From around 2022 onward, new businesses such as specialty cafés, restaurants, hostels, boutique stays, and art and design spaces have moved into historic shophouses, adding contemporary creative and tourism-oriented activities to the remnants of Songwat's wholesale trading past (The Nation, 2024). This process is similar to those seen in other Asian historic commercial districts, where logistical degradation purposefully preserves architectural heritage, which later attracts tourism and creative-led investment.

Specifically, this refers to a common pattern in Asian port and trading districts: as the original wholesale, port, or market functions decline (logistical degradation), the historic buildings are retained rather than demolished, and their architectural character is then leveraged to attract tourism and creative businesses (Koktail Magazine, 2023; Nikkei Asia, 2025). In Songwat, this means that old shophouses and warehouses, once used for river-based trade, are now reused as cafés, hostels, and art galleries, turning the historic fabric into the main appeal of a “cool” lifestyle destination (The Nation, 2024; Nikkei Asia, 2025).

This same regeneration logic can be seen in several other Asian historic commercial districts. For example, in Shanghai’s Tianzifang, a former lane-house (shikumen) and light industrial area declined as a commercial/industrial hub, but its historic buildings were preserved and reused as art galleries, design studios, and boutiques, transforming it into a major creative tourism destination (Zhang, 2018). Similarly, in Penang’s George Town, a historic port and trading quarter, many old Sino-European shophouses were preserved as part of a UNESCO World Heritage site and repurposed as cafés, guesthouses, and cultural spaces, making heritage the core of its tourism and creative economy (Lim & Ooi, 2020). In Seoul’s Insadong and Jongno area, traditional market streets that lost their dominance to modern retail have been preserved and reused as cultural shops, tea houses, and galleries, creating a heritage-based cultural tourism district (Kim, 2019). Likewise, in Bangkok’s Charoen Krung Road and Talad Noi, historic port and commercial buildings that declined in their original trade functions have been adaptively reused as cafés, galleries, and design spaces, forming government-designated creative districts that rely on their historic fabric (British Council, 2023; The Nation, 2024).

4.3 Songwat’s Regeneration

Songwat's transformation from wholesale decline to creative-led regeneration demonstrates how economic shifts can create opportunities for new urban actors and imaginaries. Nikkei Asia reports that, as the old trading economy declined and the area stayed off the radar of mainstream developers, Songwat’s relatively low rents and abandoned historic buildings made it easier for local creative entrepreneurs and lifestyle businesses to establish themselves there than in many of Bangkok’s more well-known central districts (Nikkei Asia, 2025). A new generation of café owners, entrepreneurs, gallery operators, and studio owners have recreated Songwat's faded trading streets as a hub for creative hospitality, retail, and art spaces. These companies often use neighborhood histories and aesthetics as essential parts of

their branding, incorporating the neighborhood's characteristic streetscape, Chinese heritage, and trading history into their concepts and storytelling (Koktail Magazine, 2023; Contiki, 2025).

The regeneration of Songwat can be understood as a multi-actor project rather than the achievement of any single organization. It is the product of ongoing cooperation between municipal government (the Bangkok Metropolitan Administration : BMA), a national creative-economy intermediary (the Creative Economy Agency : CEA), and the grassroots entrepreneurial network Made in Songwat, which together have repositioned the neighborhood from a declining wholesale corridor into a recognized creative and heritage district (Nikkei Asia, 2025). The structure can be understood through the lens of 'distributed urban agency,' in which various actors contribute complementary capacities—policy frameworks, strategic platforms, and daily placemaking—to a shared urban transformation process (Ansell & Torfing, 2018).

Bangkok Metropolitan Administration (BMA): Long-Term Vision and Historic District Support

The Bangkok Metropolitan Administration's 20-Year Development Plan (2013–2032) outlines a long-term vision that explicitly highlights the value of historical districts and historic urban cores as assets for Bangkok's development, rather than as old areas to be bypassed. In this framework, historic cores are framed as sources of cultural identity and urban distinctiveness that can enhance Bangkok's competitiveness in tourism and the creative economy, while also improving residents' quality of life through walkable, mixed-use neighborhoods and community-based heritage activities. This policy approach positions traditional areas not as obstacles to modernization but as strategic nodes within a more polycentric and livable city, thereby offering a justification for promoting regeneration in places like Songwat and committing the city to protecting cultural heritage, promoting urban livability, and encouraging local economic activity in traditional neighborhoods (BMA, 2013).

Importantly, the plan promotes collaborative governance and decentralization by encouraging district offices to work more closely with communities and small businesses. This governance approach allows residents and business owners in areas such as Songwat to align their initiatives—such as organizing events, improving streetscapes, or adaptively reusing historic buildings—with official policy objectives, including tourism development, the creative

economy, and community well-being (Bangkok Metropolitan Administration, 2013). As the deputy mayor of BMA explains:

“The vision is to make the government smaller and facilitate the people more... Instead of the government deciding what to do, citizens propose what they want.” (Interview, 20 August 2025)

Interviews with senior city officials further illustrate how this policy vision is operationalized in practice. He emphasizes the identification of “creative districts” as a strategic tool to activate neighborhoods and reframes the role of the city government from a top-down provider to a facilitator.

“Our role is probably clear that... make the BMA more accessible to people. Be a middleman for creators to access cooperation... access capital sources.” (Interview, 20 August 2025)

At the same time, the interviews highlight that inter-agency fragmentation remains a key challenge, particularly across public space management, tourism, and cultural policy.

“One of the major challenges mentioned was inter-agency coordination... the city must work closely with over ten different organizations.” (Interview, 20 August 2025)

This institutional shift is also confirmed by CEA senior officer, who observes that stronger central coordination under the BMA’s officer has improved clarity of responsibilities among BMA agencies and district offices.

“Once the BMA passed [coordination] to the Deputy Governor... all the agencies... sit in one room... so the district knows what they should do and what they should support.” (Interview, 13 October 2025)

Creative Economy Agency (CEA): Old-Town Strategy, Limited Budgets, and Symbolic Amplification

The Creative Economy Agency works at the intersection of national policy and local creative practice, with a mission to promote creative industries and test new forms of urban development in historic areas. The goal of CEA's old town development strategy is to revitalize

older Thai neighborhoods as creative destinations where local entrepreneurship, design, and culture can coexist with heritage preservation (CEA, 2024). In practice, this involves using tools such as creative festivals, adaptive reuse of historic buildings, and support for small creative enterprises to activate underused spaces, while working with residents to safeguard local ways of life and ensure that economic gains from tourism and the creative economy flow back into the community. This strategy has been used in other cities to connect neighborhoods to national and international creative networks, support cultural programming, and map local creative assets.

However, in Songwat, the Creative Economy Agency (CEA) has been unable to function as a primary investor or project owner due to significant budget limitations. Interview evidence indicates that CEA made this constraint explicit to local actors seeking support for regeneration initiatives. As CEA senior officer explains:

“They came to talk to CEA and then they ask us... about how to develop and ask us to support them, but unfortunately we have no budget to directly support them, and we just draft the process and then discuss with them in the beginning.” (Interview, 13 October 2025)

This statement underscores that CEA’s involvement from the outset was framed not around financial investment but around advisory support and early-stage process guidance.

As a result of these limitations, CEA’s function shifted from that of a direct funder to a strategic intermediary that provides support through indirect and non-financial means. Rather than financing projects, the agency focused on enabling local actors to access platforms, visibility, and institutional pathways. CEA’s senior officer highlights this intermediary role by noting that

“we just try to support them but not directly... we support them through the program Bangkok Design Week... like we support the trader who wants to use the space to exhibit that creative job or showcase.” (Interview, 13 October 2025)

Through such programmatic interventions, CEA offered opportunities for local initiatives to gain exposure and legitimacy without assuming ownership or long-term financial responsibility.

In addition to providing platforms for visibility, CEA played an important role in offering connections, information, and procedural guidance to help local actors operate independently within formal governance systems. Rather than acting as a permanent mediator, the agency sought to build local capacity by facilitating direct engagement with public authorities.

“We try to connect them with the local government because in the future... once they want to do it by themselves they have to connect with the local government... they have to ask for permission or funding from the local government as well. So that’s why I try to connect with them and let them learn about how you can connect with them.”
(Interview, 13 October 2025)

This approach reflects a deliberate strategy to transfer institutional knowledge and reduce long-term dependence on CEA.

Finally, where direct funding was not possible, CEA compensated by mobilizing alternative resources, particularly in the form of promotion and media exposure. As CEA senior officer said that:

“We cannot give them the money, but we provide them the space [and] promote them with media channels.” (Interview, 13 October 2025)

Taken together, these interview insights demonstrate how budgetary constraints reshaped CEA’s institutional role in Songwat, positioning the agency as a facilitator and strategic intermediary that supports locally driven regeneration through guidance, networks, and symbolic resources rather than direct financial investment.

Bangkok Design Week (BKGDW) is one of the most important events hosted by CEA and also supports Songwat. The choice to include Songwat as one of the festival's locations attracted a large number of visitors, media attention, and professional attention to the

neighborhood, despite the fact that BKKDW funds and organizes individual projects rather than entire districts (Bangkok Design Week, 2023). As CEA senior officer succinctly explains:

"We support them through the program Bangkok design week. Like we support the the trader who want to use their space to exhibit that creative job or like showcase"

"So, for each space, creators come to pitch their ideas to us, and then we select the creator we will work with."

"We got around 1000 applications, from 1000 and then we screened to 600 and then we selected 300, and just not more than 30 that got the funding from us. The funding is up to the size of the showcase but for the rest we provided the venue like you may see in our TCDC website you will see a lot of showcases." (Interview, 13 October 2025)

During the research period, the author attended the 2025 Taiwan Excellent Commercial District Award and International Exchange Forum in Taipei. This event highlighted how commercial district networks across Asia increasingly use design, festivals, and awards to build visibility and exchange know-how. A key member of the Made in Songwat collective briefly described Songwat's experience in this context:

"During Bangkok Design 2024, our exhibition matter was never born; it only transformed how creativity can give new life to rest. Okay this slide this year our community received the WOW awards 2025 it's called the wonder of well living city award this award celebrates community that makes life better through creativity and team work. We are very happy that Songwat is now known as a place full of art, culture and friendly people. Taste of sunlight. One of our special projects is called Taste of Songwat. It's a walking tour where people explore our street, try local food and learn about the community. It shows that Songwat is a cool place for young people and artists to connect. This year in August, Songwat joined the awakening Bangkok festival for the first time. There were 12 live art installations in Songwat, and bar collaboration. The

idea is to light up our heritage area and show the good mix of all.”
(Public speech, 31 October 2025)

According to creative placemaking scholars, intermediaries are crucial not because they impose a singular vision, but because they act as “platform providers,” assembling coalitions, resources, and publicity that allow diverse actors to shape place through cultural activity (Markusen & Gadwa, 2010; Daniel&Kim, 2020). In Songwat, this platform role has been especially visible in CEA’s organization of Bangkok Design Week and related programs, which position Yaowarat–Songwat as a key creative district in the city, attract large numbers of visitors, and provide a curatorial frame, while neighborhood actors such as Made in Songwat, local cafés, galleries, and family businesses retain control over specific spatial uses, tours, and storytelling practices that animate the historic streets on an everyday basis (Creative Economy Agency, 2025; Thailand NOW, 2025).



Figure 4.17 : Map of Bangkok Design Week 2023, the first year Songwat participated.
 (Photo source : bangkokdesignweek, 2023 adapted by author)



Figure 4.18 : Exhibition in Bangkok Design Week 2024 (Photo source : bangkokdesignweek, 2023)

Made in Songwat: Grassroots Collective of Old, New, and Newcomer Businesses

If the BMA provides the structural framework and CEA the strategic platform, Made in Songwat is the actor who brings Songwat's streets and buildings to life on every single day. The initiative was created during the COVID-19 pandemic when PLAY Art House and other nearby businesses in Songwat started holding small markets and cooperative events in order to survive decreasing foot traffic. What began as a practical response to the economic downturn developed into a loosely organized but strong network of entrepreneurs who shared a passion for the neighbourhood's history and future. As Made in Songwat's members explained that the initiative began out of necessity during the pandemic :

As one of the cafe owner described the atmosphere at the beginning, when everyone was struggling to stay afloat:

“It started during COVID, when everybody had to close their shops. It was really survival mode—seriously. We were open, but there were no customers, so what were we supposed to do? Mr. A hosted something like a farmers’ market in his own gallery, and that’s when he had the idea: if we were all going to survive, we had to create power as a group.”(Interview, 10 October 2025)

The gallery owner also added that the group was founded without sponsorship:

*“In the first year, we tried to set up the group. This is my gallery house. Yeah, we do the art. We have a lot of exhibitions in one year. And this is the one that I told you we do the first event, the **play around market**, they sell food and art all together so everyone put in my gallery everything is free, because we want to support the business in Songwat. We want to grow up together. So you see we have many variations of many products, just very small event only in the Gallery and then after that we try to set up the group. This is the first year of our group with just about 10 to 15 people. I visited all together and we use the name ‘Made in Songwat 2022’ and our first event is Songwat week 2022 in the end of the year October this is we make by ourself without any sponsor we do by our own.” - (Interview , 30 September 2025)*

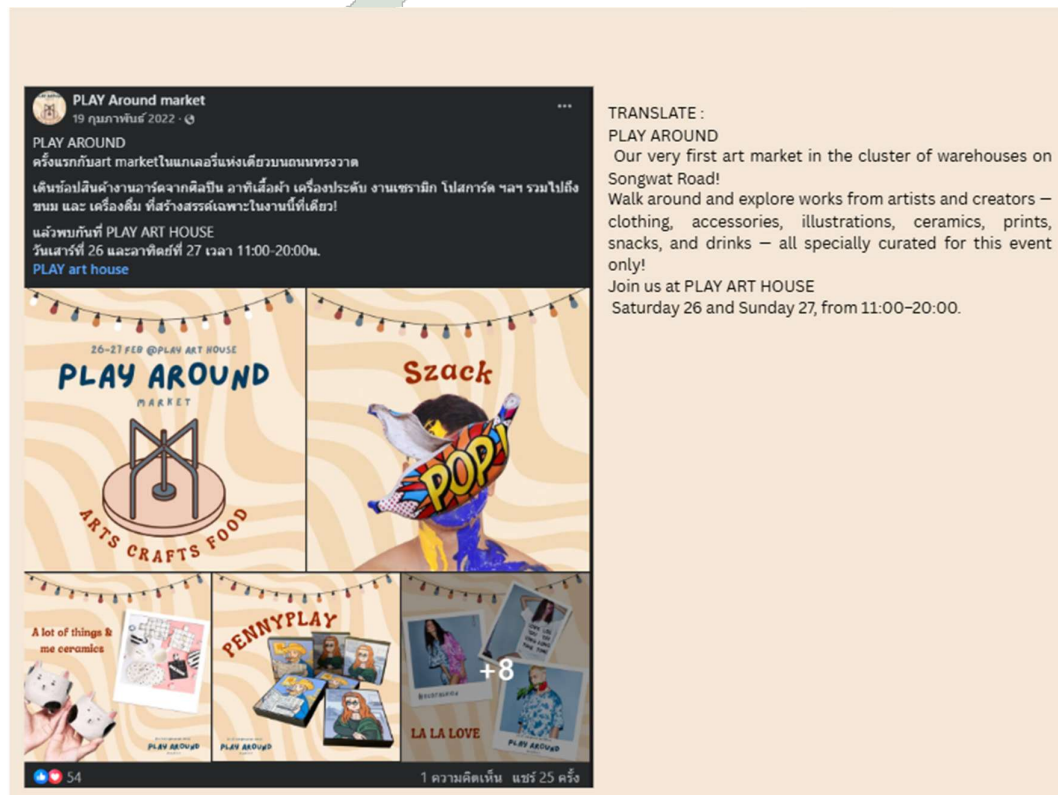


Figure 4.19 : The first event which hosted by art gallery owner in 2022 (Photo source : Facebook(PLAY Around Market), 2022)

The Made in Songwat collective is made up of three collaborative groups. First, long-standing family businesses that have been operating on Songwat Road for decades—typically

wholesalers or traders—are experimenting with diversification by adding cafés, tasting rooms, or retail corners that adapt their classic products for a new market. Second, old shophouses are being transformed into cafés, coffee shops, galleries, boutique hotels, and studios that showcase architectural details and create narratives around "old Songwat" by younger local or Bangkok-based entrepreneurs. Third, Songwat's atmospheric streetscape and increasing popularity attract newcomers from outside the district, who frequently belong to larger creative or design circles. These individuals blend themselves into existing relationships through shared events and collaboration.

Interviewees describe how Made in Songwat coordinates joint campaigns such as district guidebooks, Instagram cross-promotion, and small festivals that purposefully spread visitors across venues rather than concentrating them in only one or two "star" location. Members discuss "helping neighbours first" and "falling in love with the area before opening a shop," indicating that strong bonds and mutual support are just as important as individual business performance. As Made in Songwat key members explains :

Made in Songwat co-founder had a public speech in Taipei :

"We discuss about why don't we try the making the map let the people enjoy by the cell and from the map we try to make a guide book. We call Songwat Guidebook. We do it by ourselves again with our sponsor... we want to let the people come and explore Songwat."
(public speech, 31 October 2025)

Miss G, the Thai dessert cafe owner explains why they suppose to promote as a group:

"The idea is that people come to the community, know the community as a whole and then visit all the shops so that we all have benefited from it. So it was really simple. It was just an idea that OK, if you go to these ten different shops and get all the stamps, then you'll get the tote bag... And it worked really well for my shop as well because like you know my shop is on the 2nd floor and it's really hard to reach... basically it's just a print out of the map and the stamp for each different shop." (Interview, 10 October 2025)

Mr. K, the tea shop owner explained that *Made in Songwat* functions as a “channel” that helps promote member businesses collectively, especially during major events:

“We feel that having Made in Songwat creates an additional channel for promoting our shops—another side of promotion, so to speak. At the very least, every year when there are big events, the group acts as a platform that continuously opens up new opportunities for us. It allows us to participate in activities together, while also helping to promote all of our businesses at the same time.” (interview, 23 October 2025)

In academic terms, this reflects a shift away from strictly competitive entrepreneurialism and toward collective placemaking, in which local businesses collaborate to create a shared district identity rather than acting as isolated market actors (Markusen & Gadwa, 2010).

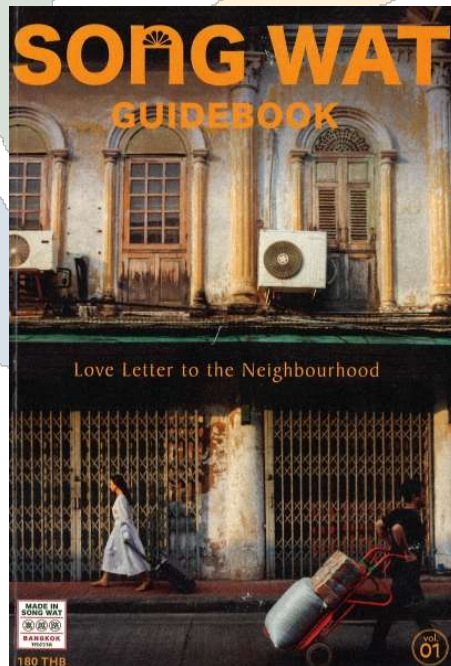


Figure 4.20 : Songwat Guidebook 1st edition published in June 2023 (Photo source : TCDC Library, 2023)

Crucially, *Made in Songwat* serves as a bridge between external institutions and the local context. The group discusses which projects fit the neighborhood's character, how to

manage visitor flows, and how to tell Songwat's stories in a way that respects long-term residents and traders when opportunities from BKKDW or other programs arise. By acting as a middleman, the collective is positioned as a vital protector of authenticity and everyday liveability, protecting against the danger that external branding could overpower local opinions.

The regeneration of Songwat can be understood as the outcome of coordinated work between municipal and national creative institutions and a tightly knit group of creative entrepreneurs, rather than an organic, unstructured process. In particular, the Bangkok Metropolitan Administration (BMA), the Creative Economy Agency (CEA), and the Made in Songwat collective have co-produced the district's regeneration through a combination of formal programs and informal elite connections. These collaborations rely not only on institutional frameworks and funding, but also on personal networks, prior professional collaborations, and the ability of key actors to move fluidly between state, corporate, and local community arenas.

Elite connections are especially visible in how private actors in Songwat mobilize their existing professional capital to engage with BMA and CEA initiatives. The elite connections shape not only access to decision-makers, but also the aesthetic and strategic direction of Songwat's regeneration. Entrepreneurs with experience in advertising, event management, and design contribute skills in visual identity, storytelling, and campaign planning, which align well with CEA's focus on creative-economy branding and with BMA's city-making strategies (CEA, 2025). As a result, collaborations between BMA, CEA, and Made in Songwat are underpinned by a shared professional culture and by trust-based relationships that make negotiation, co-organization of events, and implementation of pilot projects more efficient and less bureaucratic. In this sense, elite connections are not simply background conditions, but a key mechanism through which policy frameworks, local entrepreneurship, and cultural production are woven together in the regeneration of Songwat.

Interview narratives from Songwat's entrepreneurs underline how this collaborative configuration is reinforced by the high-capital, professional profiles of key actors. Mr. K, tea shop owner in Songwat described why the group grew quickly and how it differs from other areas:

“Basically, the entrepreneurs who came into this area all have very different backgrounds. Honestly, I feel that Songwat developed the

way it did because everyone is on the same level.” (Interview, 23 October 2025).

He further highlighted the strategic way businesses approach Songwat:

“Take the perfume shop, for example—it’s their second branch. They invested a large budget in Songwat even though they knew it was a temporary location with only a one-year lease. They treated it as advertising. This is branding marketing” (Interview, 23 October 2025).

The senior officer of CEA similarly emphasised the group’s capacity for self-reliance:

“They have very strong key actors—both shop owners and gallery owners. They are strong in terms of creativity and financial capacity, which allows them to operate independently” (Interview, 13 October 2025).

In the same vein, one of the cafe owners explained how her professional background fed directly into the collective’s capacity:

“I also work in event management, and I have my own graphic design team, so I brought my own resources. Another member helped with production. Everyone contributed according to their own expertise” (Interview, 10 October 2025).

These statements illustrate that the professional careers and resource bases of the individual actors who are able to mobilize major marketing budgets, design skills, and production teams for the neighborhood are concrete examples of elite connections. For example, members of the Hostel management team had previously worked with a senior BMA’s officer, which enabled more direct communication when proposing ideas related to neighbourhood programming and public-space use. Similarly, the owner of the specialty cafe operates a core business in advertising and runs an established agency, bringing branding expertise, production capacity, and corporate networks into the district’s collective projects. These backgrounds position such actors as brokers who can translate local entrepreneurial interests into formats and languages legible to state partners and creative-economy platforms,

reinforcing the link between institutional agendas and on-the-ground initiatives. Entrepreneurs with experience in advertising, event management, and design contribute skills in visual identity, storytelling, and campaign planning, which align with CEA's focus on creative-economy branding and with BMA's city-making strategies (CEA, 2025). As a result, collaborations between BMA, CEA, and Made in Songwat are underpinned by a shared professional culture and by trust-based relationships that make negotiation, co-organisation of events, and implementation of pilot projects more efficient and less bureaucratic.

At the same time, Songwat's regeneration is anchored in dense local ties that blur the line between elite networks and everyday community relationships. The chef from Chinese-Thai restaurant in Songwat, for instance, described how neighbourhood life is shaped by overlapping school networks:

"We are good neighbors here. Many of the shop owners I know are connected in some way. The ice cream shop owner is my old school friend, and the bar next door is run by a junior from the same school—Assumption College" (Interview, 29 September 2025).

These ties foster trust and informal cooperation, which complement more formal collaborations with state agencies. Long-established businesses also form partnerships with younger creative entrepreneurs. Miss T, the second generation of traditional wholesale business owner recalled:

"After joining Made in Songwat, I got to know the owners of the restaurants. Within just one year, we became close. They invited me to co-open the souvenir shop, and now I'm a partner in that shop" (Interview, 29 September 2025).

Meanwhile, a third-generation heir to a traditional family business who also owns a specialty restaurant described how the group's practices support older local businesses:

"We still use raw ingredients from Songwat. If there are shops run by grandparents selling beans or herbs, we continue to buy from them. It's a way of supporting each other" (Interview, 26 September 2025).

They demonstrate how elite-led regeneration is strongly linked to local supply chains, neighborhood relations, and intergenerational collaborations, rather than being separated from the existing community.

This configuration illustrates a form of distributed urban agency, in which state and non-state actors share responsibility for urban change through overlapping roles and iterative collaboration (Ansell & Torfing, 2018). The CEA offers strategic direction and visibility through its old-town and design-week events, the BMA provides a supportive governance framework and administrative legitimacy, and Made in Songwat collective transforms the neighborhood everyday landscape through the use of local knowledge, affective attachment, entrepreneurial creativity, and strong social connections. Without any of these actors, Songwat would not be as well-known or symbolically charged than it is today: a lack of grassroots collaboration would weaken the district's authenticity and lived texture, a lack of municipal support would limit experimentation, and a lack of CEA platforms would limit recognition (Bangkok Metropolitan Administration, 2013; Creative Economy Agency, 2024).

In this context, Songwat's regeneration is most effectively described as a collaborative co-production between public authorities, a national creative-economy agency, and a diverse local entrepreneurial community whose elite profiles and community connections combine to transform past decline into a platform for heritage valuation and creative elites-led regeneration.

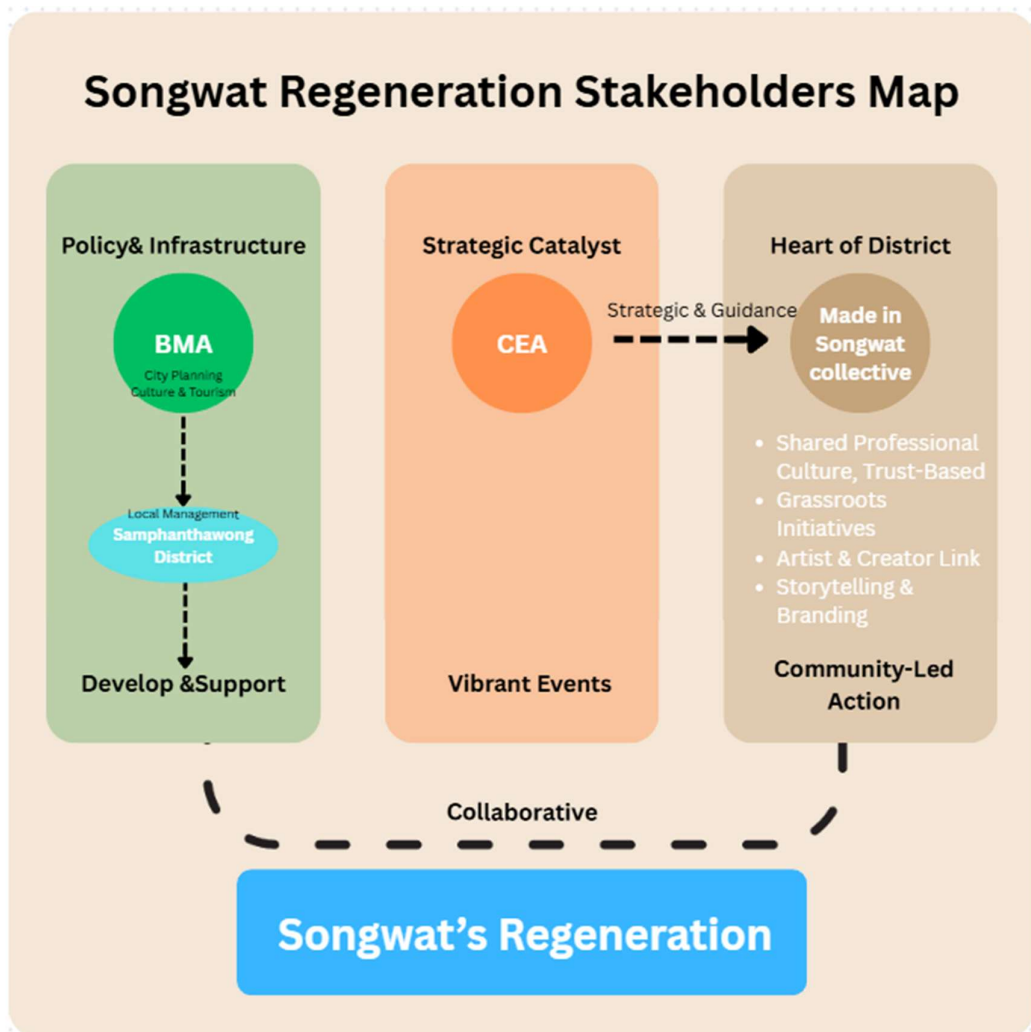


Figure 4.21 : Demonstration how collaboration between the BMA, CEA, and Made in Songwat.

Chapter 5

Creative Elite-Led Regeneration and Placemaking in Songwat

This chapter examines how creative entrepreneurs, designers, and curators have acted as placemakers, transforming Songwat from a quiet shopping street into one of Bangkok's most recognizable creative districts. Drawing on interview data and digital traces from Instagram and Facebook, it explores how small-scale elites reused shophouses, organized cultural events, and narrated local heritage in new ways. Through everyday practices, these placemakers cultivated a distinctive district identity that now circulates widely in media, tourism discourse, and global branding. Their actions have positioned Songwat as both a site of authentic heritage and a showcase of urban creativity, attracting new visitors, investors, and international attention.

Figure 5.1 illustrates the distribution of businesses in Songwat in 2025, highlighting the main road and differentiating zones such as Sampheng and the connection to Yaowarat. The map categorizes various types of establishments—including traditional handmade shops, hotels, abandoned properties, wholesale businesses, creative enterprises, and cafés/restaurants—providing a spatial overview of economic activity and the concentration of creative and heritage-oriented businesses along Songwat Road.

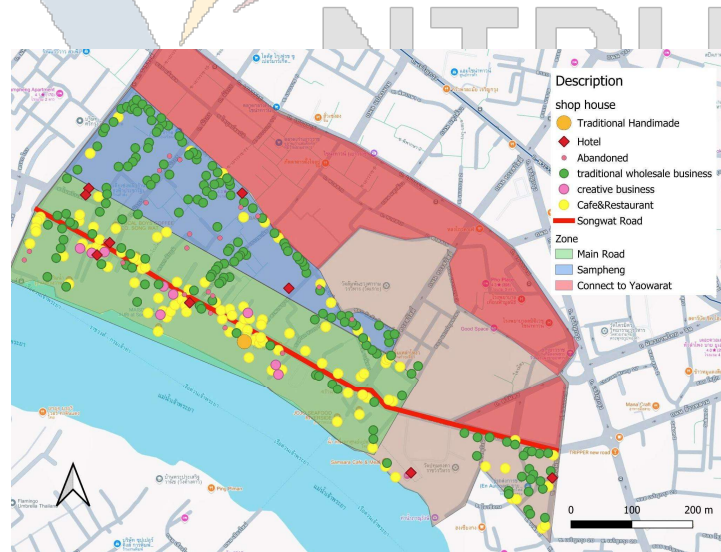


Figure 5.1: Businesses in Songwat in each zone, focus on main road (Photo source: Author, 2025)

5.1 Placemaking and the New Image of Songwat

Songwat's regeneration unfolded organically rather than through a formal plan. Beginning around the late 2010s, creative entrepreneurs—many of them designers, café owners, and curators—saw potential in the district's vintage Chinese shophouses and riverside character. They began renovating old buildings into cafés, galleries, restaurants, and small studios. While preserving historic façades and wooden beams, they introduced modern interiors, branding, and design elements that reflected contemporary aesthetics but retained the site's sense of authenticity. As shop owners explains :

The design studio and bar owners explains :

*"So I open the business 5 years ago first with my **graphic design studio** and visual lab... I choose Songwat because I fell in love with Songwat many many years ago... I like the **architecture the buildings here**, the story behind the streets." (Interview, 28 September 2025)*

The Chinese-Thai restaurant owner expressed how impressive of original structure of the building:

*"When I break down the ceiling then I see like **how beautiful the wood**... I didn't see that at the first time... but when they open the door for me I just have some kind of feeling that something is calling me... so I break down everything... I see all the **bricks** and everything is just like wow! (Figure 5.2)" (Interview, 29 September 2025)*

As a specialty café owner, she explains the period during which the shophouse was renovated:

*"I chose this building for its historical significance and transformed it into a shop due to my admiration for **stained glass (Figure 5.3)** ... While budget constraints have hindered full renovations, I've prioritized safety measures like adding a sound-absorbing wall and installing barriers on the stairs." (Interview, 10 October 2025)*

These practices exemplify *adaptive reuse*, described by Kilpatrick (2008) as the transformation of older structures for new uses while maintaining their essential form. In Songwat, this approach produced spaces that were simultaneously nostalgic and forward-looking—places where coffee counters stood beside century-old tiles and vintage trading signs. Through these tactile gestures, placemakers turned physical heritage into lived experience and contributed to what Markusen & Nicodemus (2014) describe as the narrative and sensory dimensions of creative placemaking.

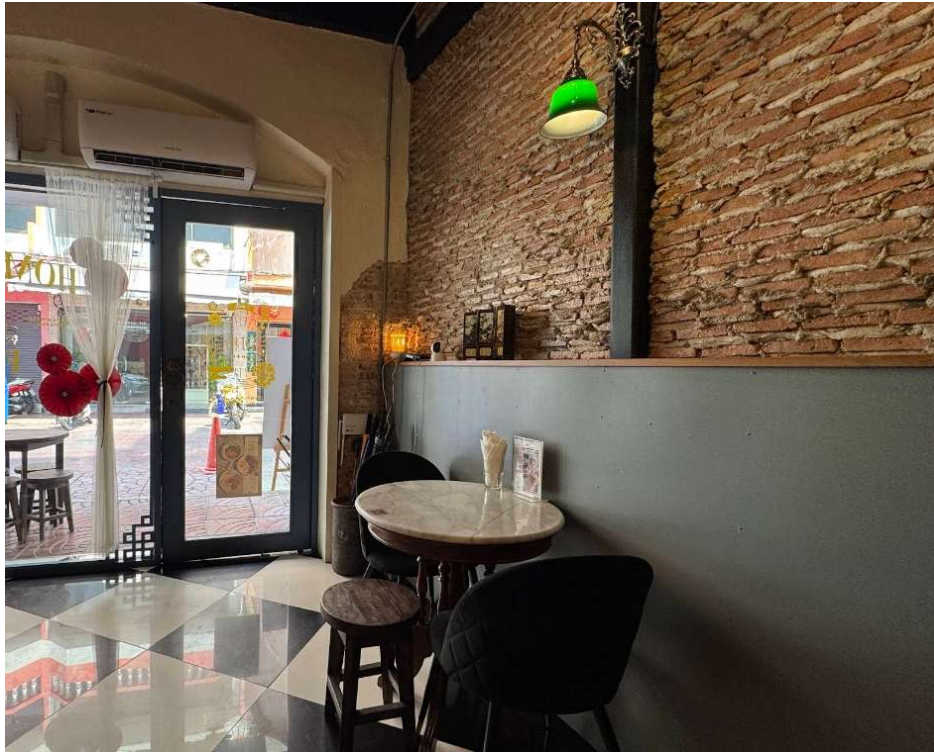


Figure 5.2 : Interior of a modern Chinese restaurant adapted from a century-old building, highlighting exposed brick walls and original structural elements.

(Photo source : Google Maps (Gim Ponlawat), 2025)

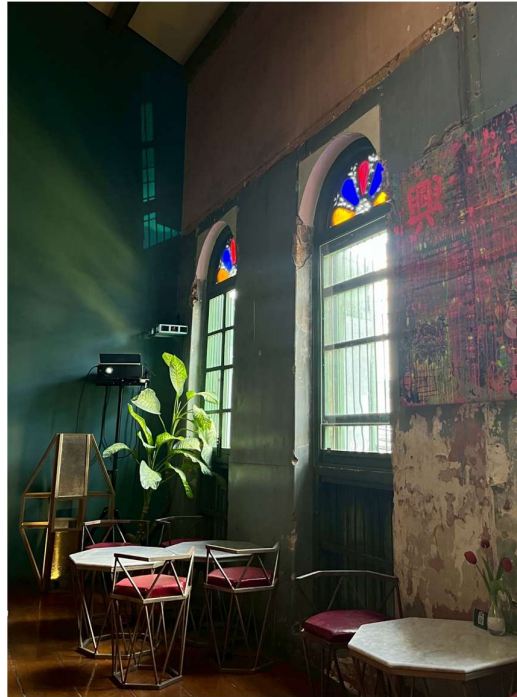


Figure 5.3 : Thai dessert cafe which adapted and decorated the old building (Photo source : author, September 2025)

The strategy of placemaking also used temporary or low-cost interventions to animate the district. Pop-up markets, art walks, and small festivals, such as *Songwat Week*, transformed alleys and courtyards into open-air cultural venues. These events encouraged walking, discovery, and casual encounters, echoing Jacobs's (1961) vision of lively streets emerging from repeated, diverse uses rather than top-down design. Social media posts amplified these scenes: photographs of restored signs, quiet morning cafés, and bustling weekend markets framed Songwat as a hidden, photogenic neighborhood worth exploring.



Figure 5.4 : Songwat week 2024's atmosphere (Photo source : nationthailand, 2024)

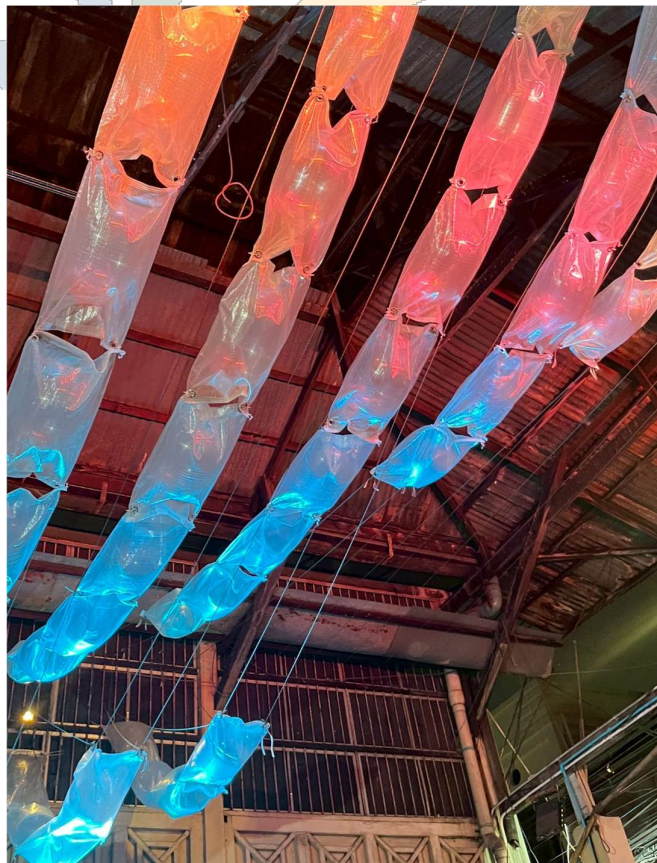


Figure 5.5 : Light Exhibition 'Awakening 2025' (Photo source : author, August 2025)

Event Date	Event Name	Type / Format	Evidence of engagement / imp
26-27 February 2022	Play Around Market @ Songwat	Weekend creative market using alleys and shophouses	Described as drawing large crowds of young Thais and tourists, with heavy Instagram coverage of stalls, vintage shops, and alleyway installations. It helped introduce many first-time visitors to Songwat as a creative market street.
4-12 February 2023	Bangkok Design Week 2023	Part of Bangkok Design Week routes / programs	The inclusion of Songwat in BKKDW routes connected the area to a festival that attracts around 400,000 visitors citywide per year, bringing design tourists and creative professionals to a street they might otherwise overlook.
19 August - 3 September 2023	ManSuang x Song Wat Festival	Cross-promotion event between the film ManSuang and Songwat	The organizers reported that “the response exceeded our expectations” and that the Songwat arts and culture area was “notably bustling throughout the 16-day festival,” while social media content (reels, fan vlogs, and posts under #ManSuangXSongWat) showed large numbers of fans visiting the neighborhood specifically because of the collaboration, significantly boosting Songwat’s visibility among Thai and international BL/fandom audiences.

3-12 November 2023	Songwat week 2023	District-scale festival	Framed as “opening a new creative tourism neighborhood for Bangkok” and explicitly linked to Songwat’s status as one of Time Out’s 40 “coolest neighborhoods,” with multi-day programs and social-media promotion via Made in Song Wat’s channels indicating strong engagement and heightened visibility among Thai and international visitors.
7-10 November 2024	Songwat Week 2024 (Theme “Songwat Cross”)	District-scale festival	Media report that Songwat Week 2024 “transforms” the historic street, with more than 60 local businesses participating (up from about 10 at the project’s start), indicating sharply increased commercial and visitor activity even though exact headcounts are not given.
8-17 August 2025	Awakening Song Wat 2025	Light & digital art festival	Over 12 immersive light installations plus bar collaborations turned the whole street into a night-time gallery, under the theme “Culturalight”. Promoted widely on tourism portals and social media in Thai, English, and Chinese, making Songwat a major nocturnal attraction, though no official visitor number is published.

20-23 November 2025	Song Wat Week 2025 – “Where Heritage Meets Creativity”	Four-day festival expanding the 2024 format	Every alley, warehouse, and shopfront is described as opening for art, workshops, street culture, and markets; national and international-facing media encourage visitors to explore “every corner” of Songwat, indicating strong footfall and online engagement.
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Table 5.1 : shows the major events that happened in Songwat and brought more visibility(Mongkol, 2025; CEA, n.d.; Be on Cloud, 2023; Naewna, 2023; Hock, 2024; SAWASDEE THAILAND, 2025; Thailand exhibition, 2025).



Awards and Recognitions of Song Wat

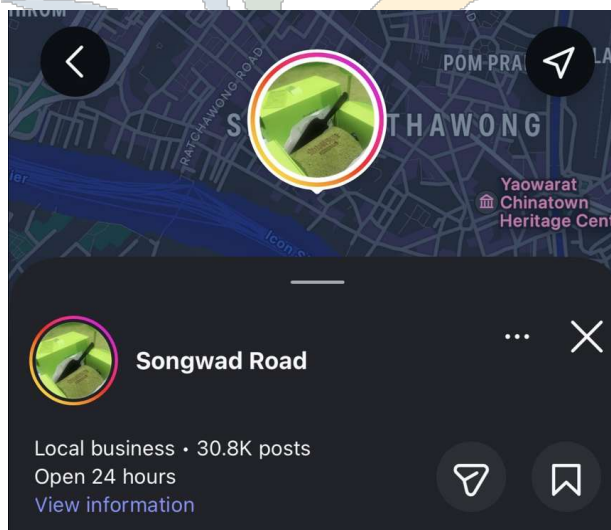
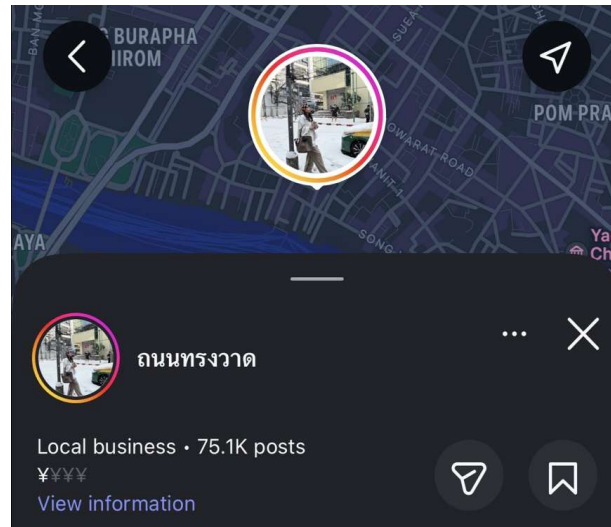
Year	Award / Recognition	Awarding Organization	Brief Description of Significance
2023	Ranked 39th in “World’s 40 Coolest Neighborhoods 2023”	Time Out	Time Out ranked Song Wat 39th globally as one of the “coolest neighborhoods” based on community character, new creative businesses, and walkable, livable urban atmosphere.
2025	WOW Awards 2025 (under the theme “Healthy City, Empowers People”)	WOW Awards Committee (linked to the Association of Siamese Architects and urban-living festival partners)	Songwat received a WOW Award in 2025 as a neighborhood that improves quality of life through creativity and community collaboration, strengthening its image as a people-centered, art- and culture-driven urban community.

Table 5.2 : This table demonstrates that Songwat has shifted from a traditional trading corridor into a recognized creative-heritage neighborhood that now carries both international visibility and domestic policy attention.

Engagement on Social Media

Platform		Description
Facebook	 Made in Song Wat ผู้ติดตาม 4.5 พัน คน • กำลังติดตาม 9 คน MADE IN SONG WAT COMMUNITY "Where heritage meets creativity." ศูนย์วัฒนธรรม	As of 30 December 2025, the Made in Song Wat Facebook page has approximately 4.5K followers.
Instagram	 madeinsongwat MADE IN SONG WAT COMMUNITY 183 posts · 7,012 followers · 75 following "Where heritage meets creativity." Song Wat Rd - Bangkok... more SW 2024 Somewhere i... THE DINNER ... SONGWAT W... LaunchBookG... Song Wat Fri... SONG WAT ...	As of 30 December 2025, the madeinsongwat Instagram account has 7,012 followers.

Instagram



As of 31 December 2025, the Instagram location tag “ถนนทรงวาด” (Song Wat Road) has approximately 75.1K posts.

The Instagram location tag “Songwad Road” has approximately 30.8K posts.

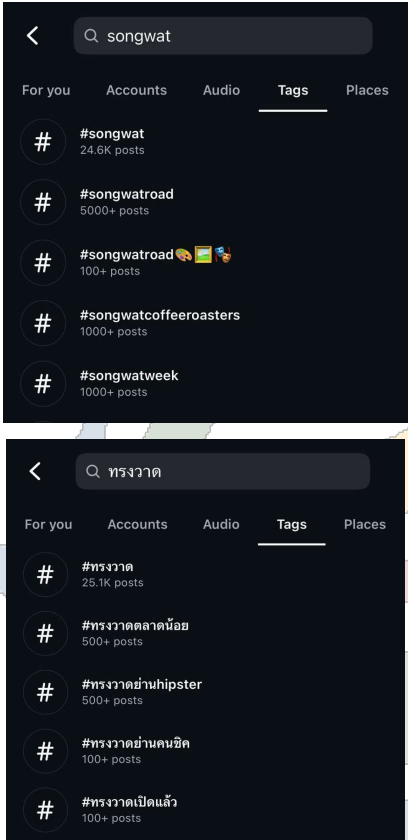
Instagram		As of 31 December 2025, the five most-used Instagram hashtags related to Songwat are: #songwat – 24.6K posts #songwatroad – 5,000+ posts #songwatroad (art-themed variant with emojis) – 100+ posts #songwatcoffeeroasters – 1,000+ posts #songwatweek – 1,000+ posts The five most-used Thai-language Instagram hashtags related to Songwat are: #ทรงวาด – 25.1K posts #ทรงวาดตลาดน้อย – 500+ posts #ทรงวาดย่านhipster – 500+ posts #ทรงวาดย่านคนชิว – 100+ posts #ทรงวาดเปิดแล้ว – 100+ posts
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Table 5.3 : Overview of social media engagement related to Songwat (Instagram, 2025)

The Table 5.3 presents an overview of social media engagement related to Songwat by summarizing follower counts and post volumes from major platforms such as Facebook and Instagram. This table highlights the level of online visibility and interest in Songwat, underscoring its role as a creative neighborhood that attracts significant attention from social media users and visitors.

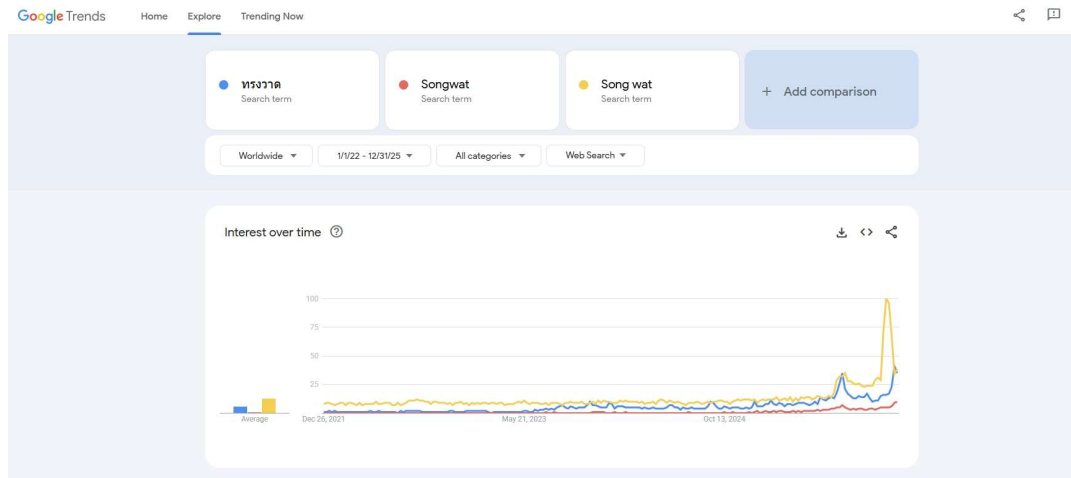


Figure 5.6 : Google Trends data for worldwide web searches (Photo source : Google Trends, 2025)

Figure 5.6 shows Google Trends data for worldwide web searches of the terms “Songwat”, “Songwat” and “Song wat” between January 2022 and December 2025, with all three series remaining at low, fluctuating levels until mid-2024 before rising gradually and then spiking sharply in late 2025, indicating a sudden surge of global search interest in the neighborhood under both Thai- and English-language spellings.

After mid-2024, the lines start to climb slowly, meaning that more people are searching for Songwat on a regular basis, not just in short bursts. This gradual rise fits with the idea that new cafés, galleries, and online stories about the area were helping to build a more stable image of Songwat as a riverside heritage and creative neighborhood.

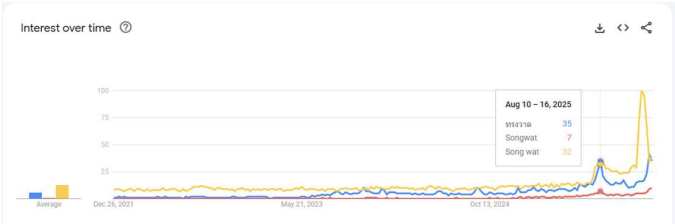
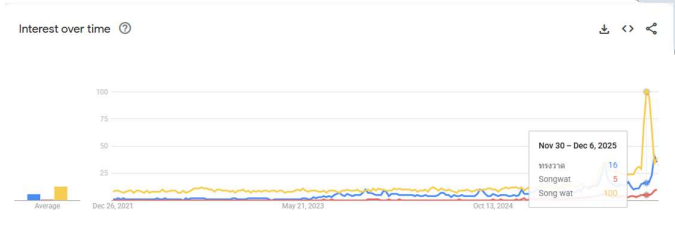
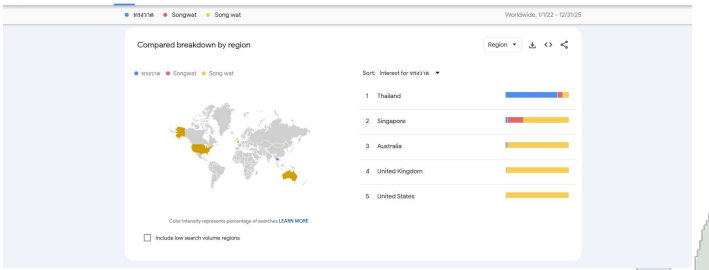
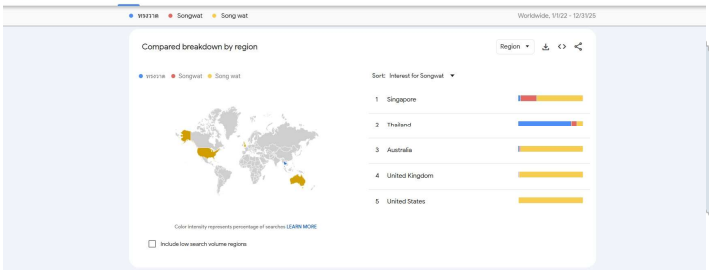
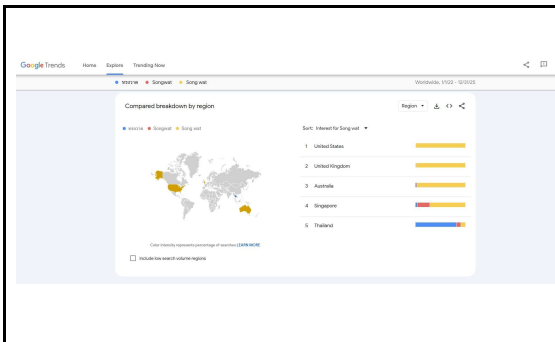
Graph	Description
	The high point in August 2025 can be linked to Awakening Songwat 2025, a light and digital-art festival held in the neighborhood during the same period. Because the event overlapped with Thailand’s Mother’s Day long weekend in mid-August, many people had time off and were more likely to look for activities and places to visit, which likely pushed up searches related to Songwat.
	In the end of 2025 brings a very clear change. All three search terms jump sharply and reach a high peak. This sharp increase likely reflects a specific event, Songwat Week, a four-day creative festival held along Songwat Road from 20–23 November 2025, which brought significant attention to the neighborhood. Overall, the figure illustrates how a once little-known commercial district became a visible creative-heritage destination in global online searches within only a few years.

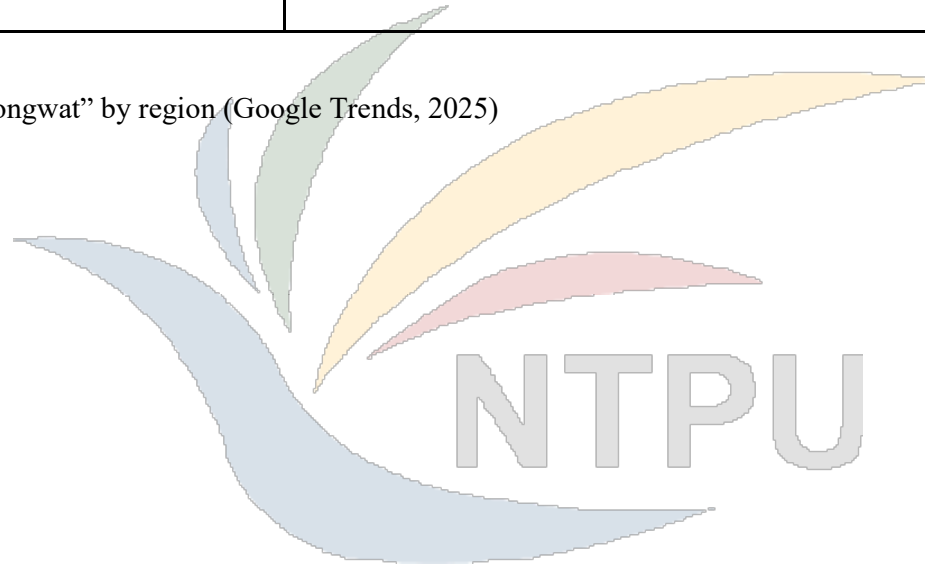
Table 5.4 : Analysis of Search Interest Spikes for Songwat (Google Trends, 2025)

Graph	Descriptions
 Google Trends Home Explore Trending Now Worldwide, 11/22 - 12/25/25 Compared breakdown by region Region: Worldwide Sort: Interest for ทรูวาด 1 Thailand 2 Singapore 3 Australia 4 United Kingdom 5 United States Color intensity represents percentage of searches LEARN MORE ☐ Include low search volume regions	compares the regional distribution of Google search interest for “ทรูวาด,” “Songwat,” and “Song wat” (worldwide, 2022–2025), showing that Thailand dominates searches using the Thai spelling “ทรูวาด,” while Singapore, Australia, the United Kingdom, and the United States register smaller but visible levels of interest, particularly under the English spellings(Google trend, 2025).
 Google Trends Home Explore Trending Now Worldwide, 11/22 - 12/25/25 Compared breakdown by region Region: Worldwide Sort: Interest for Songwat 1 Singapore 2 Thailand 3 Australia 4 United Kingdom 5 United States Color intensity represents percentage of searches LEARN MORE ☐ Include low search volume regions	ranks countries by relative search interest in the term “Song wat,” indicating that the United States, United Kingdom, and Australia lead English-language searches, with Singapore and Thailand also contributing significant shares, suggesting that the English two-word form circulates mainly among overseas users and international tourists(Google trend, 2025).



ranks countries by search interest in the term “Songwat,” showing that Singapore records the highest relative interest, followed by Thailand, Australia, the United Kingdom, and the United States, which together illustrate how both Thai- and English-language spellings of the neighborhood circulate across regional tourist markets and global online audiences(Google trend, 2025).

Table 5.5 : Global interest in “Songwat” by region (Google Trends, 2025)



Google Trends data indicate that Songwat’s visibility increased sharply only after late 2024. From 2022 to mid-2024, search interest in “ทรงวาด,” “Songwat,” and “Song wat” remained low, suggesting limited public awareness. A clear surge appears in 2025, aligning with international media recognition, major cultural events, and intensified social-media circulation. Regional search data further show that Thai-language queries are concentrated within Thailand, while English-language terms attract attention from countries such as Singapore, Australia, the United Kingdom, and the United States. This pattern suggests that Songwat’s rising prominence was driven not only by physical regeneration and events on the ground, but also by their amplification through searchable online content that extended visibility from domestic to international audiences.

As visibility grew, Songwat began to function as a *creative stage*—a backdrop for artistic expression, influencer photography, and brand collaboration. The district’s aesthetic of “authentic cool” attracted media coverage and cultural partnerships. Global-facing brands such as Birkenstock and local designers staged exhibitions within its shophouses, merging commercial and cultural imagery. This form of place branding aligns with Florida’s (2004, 2012) idea of creating a “people climate,” in which artistic vibrancy signals openness and innovation. Through these activities, Songwat became not only a creative community but also a recognizable symbol of “Bangkok at its coolest”.



Figure 5.7 : Songwat partnered with Birkenstock on a collaborative project , (Photo source : Instagram(@tumcial), 2024)



Figure 5.8 : Collaborative between Songwat's shophouse and Nescafé (Photo source : author 2025).

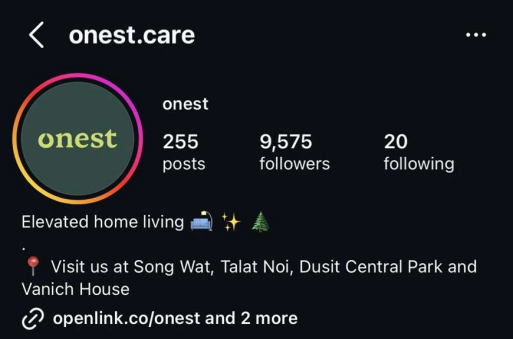
Brand	Description
 The screenshot shows the Instagram profile of skonxperfumery. The profile picture is a circular logo with 'SKONX' in the center. The bio states: 'Trust our scent experts to make you 'Smells Unique'' followed by a list of locations: '- 2nd Floor, Gaysorn Village', '- Song Wat Road', '- 2nd Floor, Central Park', and '- 2nd Floor, Central World'. It also mentions 'Gaysorn village, Bangkok, Thailand' and includes a linktr.ee link. The post count is 287, followers are 3,745, and following is 31.	The Instagram profile of Skonx Perfumery, a multi-branch niche perfume retailer, has locations in Gaysorn Village, Song Wat Road, Central Park, and Central World in Bangkok.
 The screenshot shows the Instagram profile of onest.care. The profile picture is a circular logo with 'onest' in the center. The bio states: 'Elevated home living' followed by a list of locations: 'Visit us at Song Wat, Talat Noi, Dusit Central Park and Vanich House'. It also includes an openlink.co link. The post count is 255, followers are 9,575, and following is 20.	The Instagram profile of onest.care, a lifestyle and home-care brand. The profile lists multiple physical locations—Song Wat, Talat Noi, Dusit Central Park, and Vanich House—indicating how the brand expands its reach across several creative districts while maintaining a curated visual identity.
 The screenshot shows the Instagram profile of oysterandthingss. The profile picture is a circular logo with 'Oyster & Things' in the center. The bio states: 'The concept store offer selected things from head to toe' followed by 'New branch!! at Songwat' and 'HQ Shop @bluewild.space'. It also mentions 'BTS Thonglor exit 2' and includes a shopee link. The post count is 1,954, followers are 42.9K, and following is 33.	The Instagram profile of oysterandthingss, a verified concept store which curates selected lifestyle products “from head to toe.” The profile announces a new branch at Songwat while indicating its headquarters at Bluewild Space near BTS Thonglor, underscoring how expanding to Songwat becomes part of the brand’s multi-location retail strategy.

Table 5.6 : Examples of shops with multiple branches beyond Songwat

5.2 Elite Network and Impact on Regeneration

Although this transformation is underpinned by a small but influential network of creative elites, many placemakers in Songwat had already built careers in other creative districts such as Ari, Charoenkrung, and Thonglor, or in design, fashion, and hospitality sectors before opening their Songwat ventures. These entrepreneurs tend not to be typical small-scale operators but experienced professionals with substantial financial resources, treating Songwat as a strategic site for experimentation, branding, and visibility rather than merely a place for basic livelihood trading. These backgrounds provide them with both business acumen and social capital—the capacity to identify undervalued properties, mobilize investment, and coordinate collaborations across industries.

Several figures also had family connections to Songwat, inheriting shophouses or maintaining long-standing ties to the old trading community. These relationships lent symbolic legitimacy and eased negotiations with property owners and regulators. Together, they formed what Basu (2018) calls an *urban elite coalition*, where locally embedded yet globally connected entrepreneurs steer cultural regeneration through informal governance structures. As Miss P, the third-generation successor of a traditional family business—while her brother has remained in charge of the family’s traditional wholesale operations—who has also established a specialty fusion restaurant explains:

“Honestly, at first I didn’t want to do anything related to my family business at all. It wasn’t until I went to study abroad that the program encouraged us to create something practical—something that could actually be implemented. That became the starting point for developing a business plan for an agar(jelly) cafe.”

“My grandfather was just an ordinary Chinese immigrant. When he arrived, he simply sold what he saw others selling. Black-brand agar powder originated in Songwat. What makes our café special is that everything supports each other—the factory is right next door. It really feels like our brand was born in Songwat and continues to exist in Songwat.” (Interview, 26 September 2025)

Groups of Songwat elites share a similar “level”

Group	Description / Basis of Connection	Examples for the group	Distinctive Features / Resources Enabling Cooperation
“Elite Network”	Experienced, well-funded entrepreneurs sharing similar social and professional capital. They view their ventures as brand extensions rather than survival businesses.	- Perfume Shop owners - Thai style specialty cafe owner - Specialty restaurant owner - Tea shop owner - Giftshop owners	These entrepreneurs share three key characteristics: - Comparable financial capacity, enabling them to operate at a similar “elite” level. - Strong professional and business experience, often shaped by prior corporate or educational backgrounds. A long-term, branding-oriented approach, viewing their ventures as image-building investments rather than immediate income sources.

“Multi-Business” Professionals	Entrepreneurs running multiple businesses with in-house creative resources (staff, designers, production teams), enabling smooth, independent collaboration.	- Thai dessert cafe owner - Thai style specialty cafe owner - Hostel’s team management	- These entrepreneurs are self-sufficient, possessing their own financial resources, staff, and creative teams. - Their internal capacity allows them to organize community events like Songwat Week independently. They use in-house branding and design expertise instead of relying on external or government support..
Alumni Network	A subgroup of male entrepreneurs bonded through shared schooling , creating immediate trust and informal coordination.	- Chinese-Thai fusion restaurant owner - The Bar owner - Gallery owner/Made in Songwat leader)	- Members share deep personal trust rooted in their shared school background, which they describe as a form of “destiny.” - This bond fosters informal partnerships and mutual support. It makes collaboration and joint promotion effortless within the network.

“Heirs” (Second / Third Generation Returnees)	Property owners or inheritors returning to redevelop family assets; free from rental pressure, enabling creativity-focused projects.	- Traditional business owners - Gallery owner/Made in Songwat leader)	- These individuals have financial stability and property ownership, allowing them to take a long-term, heritage-oriented approach. - They actively collaborate with partners to revitalize ancestral properties. They work to preserve the neighborhood’s cultural legacy.
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Table 5.7 : Groups of Songwat elites share a similar “level”

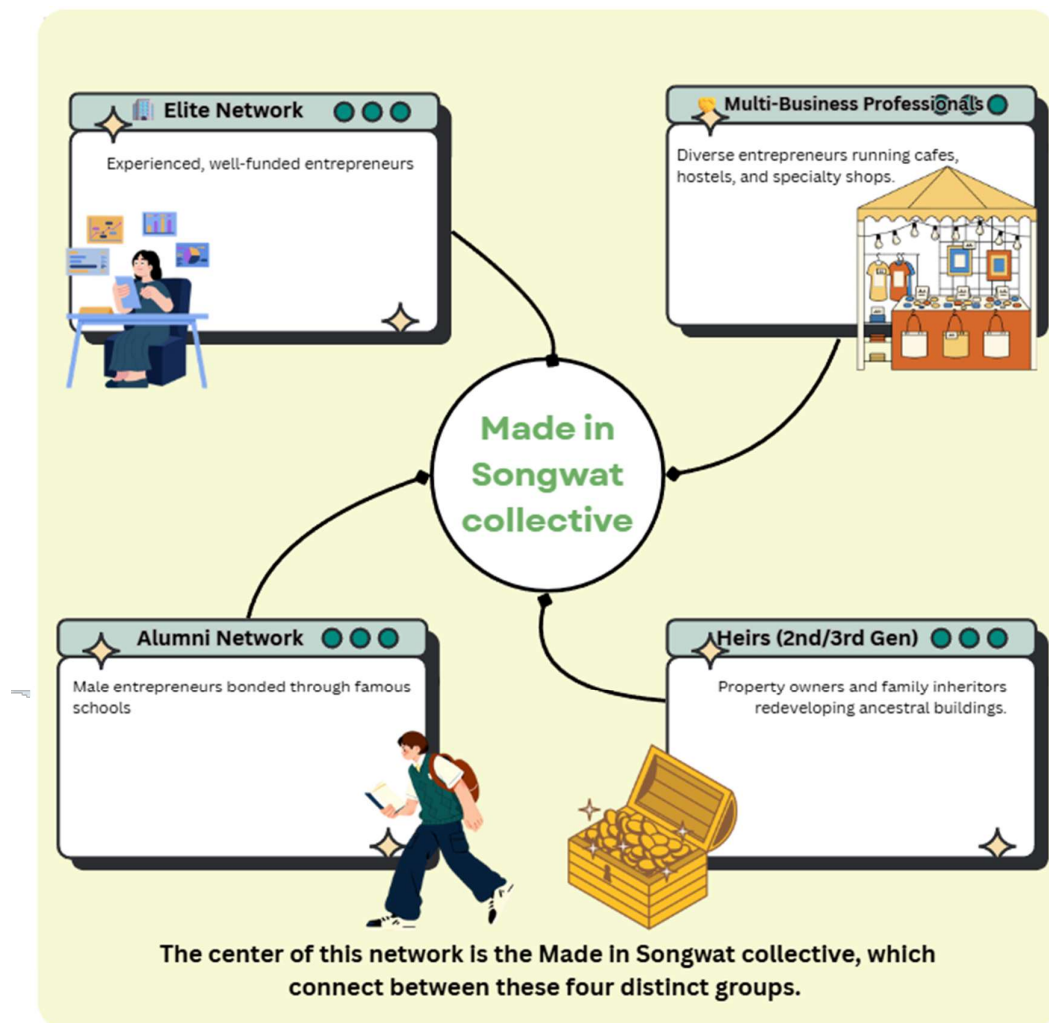


Figure 5.9 : Mapping the Elite Ecosystem: Connections and Shared Agency among Songwat Entrepreneurs

Table 5.7 and Figure 5.9 show how different groups of Songwat entrepreneurs share a similar “level” of capital, **experience**, and **social connections** that makes collaboration particularly easy and effective. It highlights the specific resources and social ties each subgroup contributes including financial security, in-house professional teams, alumni networks, and inherited property, and explains how these shared advantages translate into smooth cooperation in neighborhood projects and creative regeneration.

In terms of property, most of the new creative businesses in Songwat do not own their buildings but instead operate as tenants in privately held shophouses, some of which are owned by long-standing Chinese–Thai families and some by institutional landlords such as the Crown Property Bureau. Rather than a simple divide between "landed locals" and "incoming outsiders," ownership in the area is fragmented and layered: a small number of families and large landlords own the building stock, while creative entrepreneurs—many of whom are well capitalized but still renters—compete for access to suitable spaces. This structure reinforces existing power and value hierarchies, as the appreciation generated by creative-led regeneration mainly benefits property owners through rising rents and land values, whereas most new businesses continue to face lease uncertainty and future rent increases.

Within this configuration, certain locally rooted elites play an important coordinating role in connecting creative entrepreneurs with available space. Kiattiwat, co-founder of PLAY Art House, founder of Made in Songwat and a long-term Songwat resident, exemplifies this position. Because he has lived in the neighbourhood for many years and maintains relationships with multiple building owners, he is often the person newcomers contact when they want to open a business in Songwat. He helps identify vacant units, introduces prospective tenants to landlords, and, in some cases, advises both sides on what kinds of uses might fit the street's emerging image. This informal real estate function shows how insider creative elites not only run their own businesses, but also negotiate access to space, determining who can enter the district as an operator and under what terms. It also demonstrates that Songwat's regeneration is a negotiated process in which access to property is heavily influenced by social ties, trust, and long-term presence in the neighborhood, rather than a free market with equal competitors.

The resulting network functions as an ecosystem of shared trust and distributed leadership. Entrepreneurs co-organize festivals, cross-promote one another's spaces, and jointly negotiate with state agencies. Groups like *Made in Songwat* exemplify this model, combining individual autonomy with collective identity building. Agencies such as the Creative Economy Agency (CEA) and Bangkok Metropolitan Administration (BMA) play enabling roles within this ecology—amplifying

Songwat's visibility through platforms like *Bangkok Design Week* while respecting its grassroots authenticity (CEA, 2023).

However, this relational structure also shapes which narratives are foregrounded. Instagram campaigns and curated events tend to highlight heritage cafés, design boutiques, and artisanal products, while making the neighborhood's remaining wholesale activities, storage spaces, and migrant labour far less visible. In this process, culture effectively becomes a redevelopment tool that privileges particular aesthetics and social groups over others.

5.3 Challenges: Popularity but Out of Control

Songwat's newfound reputation as a creative hub brings both success and vulnerability. As the area gains recognition from travel magazines and influencers, property values and rents have begun rising. Increasingly, long-standing wholesalers face displacement pressures, and local property owners realize the commercial potential of their once-underused assets. As the interviewees describe :

The owner of Chinese-Thai restaurant remarked that :

"I heard people say that okay example this building 20 years ago the rent is just like okay 5,000 - 20,000... the rent by that time [recently] is 80,000... if the area same building third floor whatever the is like 160,000... Of course opportunity increase your rent... but if they put too high nobody comes." (Interview, 29 September 2025)

Songwat's trajectory reflects global patterns in cultural districts where creative visibility attracts speculative interest and rising land values, but its dynamics do not neatly match classic gentrification narratives in which lower-income residents are rapidly displaced by new, wealthier populations (Bianchini & Parkinson, 1993; British Council, 2018). In this context, some long-standing landlords have directly benefited from rising land prices, gaining leverage in rent negotiations and capturing appreciation while retaining ownership, rather than being forced out of the area.

Based on interviews, there is also a strong sentiment among both older and newer business owners that the influx of visitors drawn by social media visibility does not necessarily translate into local economic gain. Many interviewees describe how tourists and influencers treat the neighborhood as a “free studio” rather than an urban common sustained through participation and spending.

The tea shop owner vividly characterizes this phenomenon as the “One Glass, Five People” problem:

“Songwat is like a street studio... It makes you want to take photos. But coming to take photos doesn’t mean they will spend at every shop... Sometimes five people come and buy only one glass.” (Interview, 23 October 2025)

Similarly, long-time resident and the second generation of traditional business owner explains that while tour groups bring visible crowds, they rarely generate proportional revenue:

“On Sundays, 200 people might come down the road... but do these 200 people actually spend in my shop? No. They enjoy seeing the place, but I don’t get involved. I even close on Sundays.” (Interview, 29 September 2025)

This perception underlines a recurring frustration. Popularity does not equal prosperity. The rising foot traffic produces congestion, aesthetic fatigue, and superficial engagement rather than broad-based local benefit.

Aesthetic consumption further amplifies this disconnect. As Miss B, a bar and design studio owner observes, many newcomers “buy for the photo, not the product.” Visitors are described as “zombies”, absorbed by their screens, oblivious to Songwat’s architecture or riverfront context:

“They’re like zombies... just following the map from Instagram or TikTok. They don’t even care about the buildings... or the river right next to them.”

“People don’t care about the quality of the coffee... they buy just to take a photo—some don’t even like coffee but feel the need to show that they’ve been to Songwat.”
(Interview, 28 September 2025)

This “*visuals over value*” economy highlights how social media logics—what Zukin (2010) calls “*aesthetic ownership*”—can erode the experiential authenticity that first attracted creatives to the area. As Miss G, the Thai dessert cafe owner reflects, the district’s image has become increasingly commercialized, prompting her to pivot toward “*authentic storytelling*”:

“Songwat is not only about the selfies or photography. This year, our theme is storytelling—we want to bring back someone’s story.” (Interview, 10 October 2025)

Spatial inequalities sharpen this divide. Miss P, the specialty fusion restaurant owner, whose shop lies outside the main “*photo street*”, notes the uneven geography of benefit:

“I don’t get that much from this hype because my shop is farther out—it’s not in the spot where the teenagers go to take photos.” (Interview, 26 September 2025)

Collectively, these accounts suggest that Songwat’s creative popularity has fostered symbolic capital without sufficiently supporting economic inclusion. The neighborhood’s creative rebranding attracts visibility, but its monetization remains uneven—concentrated in a few high-profile venues while sidelining traditional, service-oriented businesses.

At the same time, many local residents continue to live in the small alleys behind and between the renovated shophouses, even as streams of tourists now pass directly in front of their doors and windows. Some households still run small grocery stores, salon or street-side made-to-order restaurants that cater to everyday needs, maintaining forms of micro-economy that predate Songwat’s current branding.



Figure 5.10 : Local residents continue to live in the small alleys behind and between the renovated shophouses (Photo source : author, September 2025)



Figure 5.11 : Salon in the small alley in Songwat (Photo source : author, September 2025)



Figure 5.12 : Grocery store in the small alley in Songwat (Photo source : author, September 2025)

However, as cafés, restaurants, and lifestyle venues in the main streets become increasingly overpriced, these residents report feeling that they can no longer easily find “good, reasonably priced” food in what is supposed to be their own neighborhood, underscoring a growing mismatch between local cost-of-living realities and the curated consumption landscape around them. As Miss J, one of the made in Songwat members, who also living in Songwat expressed :

“We just can’t find affordable and good food in this area. The cost of living here is really high. Even the cheaper dishes are already around 100 baht. And just because it’s 100 baht doesn’t mean it’s filling or tasty.

I talked with my partner and realized that the two of us are spending almost 1,000 baht a day just on meals—that’s about 30,000 baht a month. And then what? It’s like, even if we go to Banthatthong or

nearby areas like Yaowarat, we still can't eat properly. Or the small noodle shops in the alleys may be cheaper, but still... It's tricky.

For example, a dish for 50 baht would be considered very cheap here—but right now, in this area, you almost can't find anything at that price. And when you do get a 50-baht dish, it's often unclean and comes in very small portions. Compare that to Lat Phrao or Charan, 50 baht would get you a clean, tasty, filling meal. You understand? It feels like it's really dirty here, and we experience this every day. The more the area develops, the less there is left for locals to eat—unless we cook ourselves.

Honestly, it makes you feel out of place. Like, 'why am I here?' And we were here before things got so pricey. But there's nothing we can do.

Even the cheap and clean noodle shops in Songwat? You can't really eat there either because the queues are too long. A dish costs around 60 baht there, versus 50 baht elsewhere, but the portions are tiny—specials cost 100 baht. It's all understandable; you pay for what you get. People still spend 120 baht on a cup of coffee every day now.

The cost of living is high across the board, and rent keeps going up too." (Interview, 27 September 2025)



Figure 5.13 : Menu and prices for traditional of the super famous, small noodle shops in the alleys (Photo source : Google Map (石佳涵), 2025)



Figure 5.14 : Menu and prices of the famous noodle shop in Songwat (Photo source : Google Map (WanChen Wang), 2025)



Figure 5.15 : Menu and prices of the famous stewed goose restaurant in Songwat (Photo source : Google Map (Chompunuch Kusol), 2025)

Institutionally, Songwat's transformation continues to unfold within a governance gap, where promotional agendas outpace protective frameworks (British Council, 2018). Agencies such as the CEA promote creative districts as policy tools, yet concrete regulatory instruments to safeguard affordability, support local-serving businesses, or protect everyday heritage remain limited, especially in areas dominated by privately owned shophouses. Without measures such as rent stabilization, zoning that explicitly recognizes local cultural and residential uses, or community benefit mechanisms, creative placemaking risks tipping into a pattern of overexposure, in which short-term visibility and branding overshadow long-term social and cultural sustainability (Bianchini & Parkinson, 1993).

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and branding overshadow long-term social and cultural sustainability (Bianchini & Parkinson, 1993; Harvey, 1989).

Taken together, these dynamics underline that Songwat's transformation is largely operated through a dense but relatively small grassroots elite network rather than through formal, high-capital institutions. Made in Songwat and core members rely heavily on personal relationships, social media visibility, and their ability to negotiate with district officials and sympathetic landlords, but their families are not among Bangkok's most powerful conglomerate dynasties. Their influence is therefore significant at the neighborhood scale, but structurally limited when set against large capital. Major tycoons and corporate investors possess their own far stronger networks and direct access to state and financial power; they own land, control major assets, and can organize large projects without needing to plug into grassroots coalitions. In this context, the collective's efforts to "manage" and channel Songwat's popularity—by promoting more respectful tourism, organizing district-wide festivals, and highlighting the area's social and heritage value—represent a serious attempt to steer change from below, but cannot by themselves counterbalance the longer-term pressures created by rising land values and large-scale waterfront investment.

In other words, Made in Songwat has already done as much as a grassroots creative elite can reasonably do with limited ownership and leverage; what happens next in Songwat will increasingly depend on how city authorities and large landowners choose to respond to, adopt, or override this locally grounded stewardship.

At the same time, several interviewees voiced discomfort with the direction in which Songwat is heading, arguing that the neighborhood is becoming "too commercial" and increasingly dominated by curated consumption rather than everyday life. As Thai dessert café owner explain:

"Songwat is becoming more and more commercial and it's going away from the original... I would say that in the beginning the reason we became popular it's because of... the story of the history... But then... it got into the direction that is more about the brands... it's all very commercial." (Interview, 10 October 2025)

Agar(Jelly) café owner also explains that :

"It's like they cook it up (fabricate it) until it's not Songwat anymore..... People come to Songwat to take photos of 'chic' shops..., I feel like, 'Is this Songwat?'... We don't look like Songwat at all, even though we were here first."(Interview, 26 September 2025)

For them, the rapid proliferation of cafés, pop-up concepts, and branded collaborations risks hollowing out the intimate, street-based atmosphere that made the area attractive in the first place. Some explicitly compared this trajectory to Banthat Thong, warning that Songwat could become another overexposed food and lifestyle strip—crowded, expensive, and heavily mediated by social media trends—rather than a living historic community. These concerns reveal not only tensions between visitors and residents, or between old and new businesses, but also disagreements within the creative elite itself about how much commercialization is acceptable and what should be protected as the core of Songwat’s identity.

In this context, the recently announced “The Ritz-Carlton Bangkok, The Riverside” by Asset World Corporation (AWC), spanning Lhong 1919 and parts of Song Wat Road, becomes a crucial test of how this governance gap will play out in practice.

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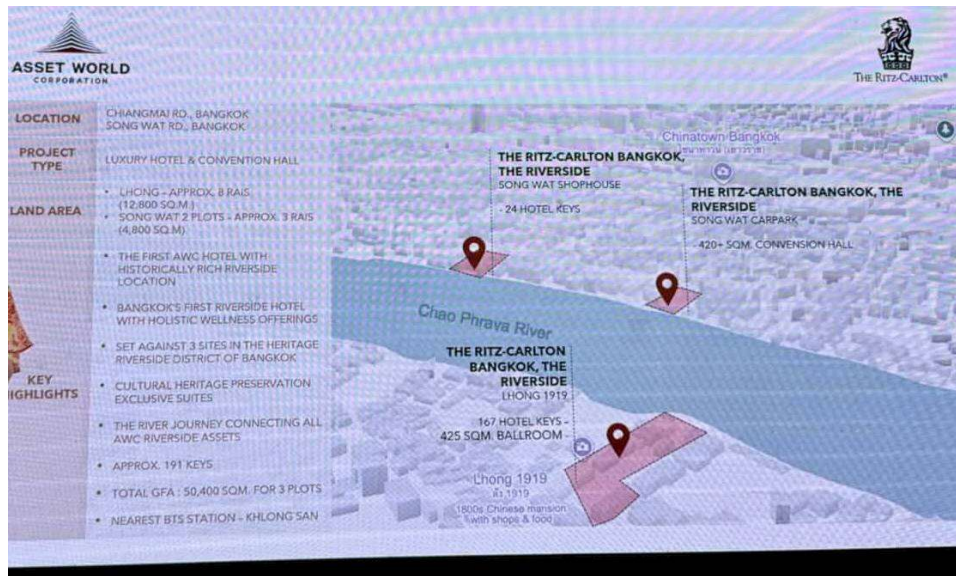


Figure 5.16 : AWC's journey project which including Songwat district in their project (Photo source : Line Today (Positioningmag), 10 June 2025)

accelerate land valorization and signal to landlords that Songwat can now be priced for global hotel and high-end visitor markets rather than everyday neighborhood uses. For small businesses and residents already struggling with rising rents and the low spending visitors, this large-scale corporate investment could strengthen existing inequalities in who benefits from Songwat's newfound visibility.

Local elites themselves often articulate ambivalence about these shifts. They welcome renewed energy, expanded networks, and diversified publics, but also express concern about congestion, the spread of “photo-op” aesthetics, and the gradual erosion of intimate, neighborly atmospheres that once defined everyday life in Songwat. These concerns resonate with critiques of “urban entrepreneurialism,” which argue that creativity and culture are frequently mobilized as instruments of territorial competition and economic growth rather than as ends in themselves. For Songwat to sustain its authenticity, future strategies will need to balance place branding with meaningful community investment and everyday affordability, ensuring that cultural regeneration remains inclusive, grounded in local agency, and resilient in the face of its own success.

In this sense, after the opening of AWC's Ritz-Carlton Bangkok, The Riverside not only adds another high-end venue, but also signifies a broader shift toward corporate-led, entrepreneurial urbanism along the Chao Phraya, putting additional strain on Songwat's regeneration in the coming years.

Chapter 6

Conclusions

In this chapter, I will conclude the empirical findings related to the research aims, which emphasize the significance and impact of Songwat Old Neighborhood's creative-led regeneration, led by local entrepreneurs and creative elites. Songwat, which is emerging as a historic creative district through collaborations between the Bangkok Metropolitan Administration (BMA), the Creative Economy Agency (CEA), and the Made in Songwat collective, is used as an empirical lens to discuss Thai urban cultural and creative economy policy. The chapter offers practical recommendations for how creative-led regeneration can be planned and implemented in Songwat, and then applies these lessons to other historic commercial areas in Thailand.

6.1 Conclusion

This section summarizes how the thesis addressed its research objectives and how the case of Songwat Old Neighborhood contributes to our understanding of creative-led regeneration in historic urban districts. The research aimed to investigate, first, who initiated Songwat's creative regeneration process and what situations and backgrounds influenced their participation in urban regeneration, and second, how different stakeholders collaborated in this process and how these interactions influenced the neighborhood's environmental, cultural, and economic growth. The main empirical findings can be summarized as follows:

- Songwat's regeneration emerged from a network of creative elites and local entrepreneurs, including café owners, gallery operators, designers, and family business heirs, who began experimenting with new uses in underutilized historic shophouses. Their participation drew on professional experience, higher education, and extensive social networks, and was enabled by structural conditions such as the decline of river-based wholesale trade, preservation of the built fabric, and relatively low rents that allowed for experimentation.
- Within this broader network, Kiattiwat Srichanwanpen, co-founder of PLAY Art House and president and founder of the Made in Songwat collective, stands out as the main initiator of Songwat's recent creative-led regeneration. He was among the first to use historic shophouses for art and cultural events during the COVID-19 period, organised early collaborative markets such as PLAY Around Market, and then formalised these

activities into the Made in Songwat group, helping to articulate a shared vision and bring together long-established family businesses and new creative ventures.

- These actors operate within a public and private sectors which distribute agency across multiple levels. The Bangkok Metropolitan Administration's 20-year development plan recognizes the importance of historic districts and promotes more collaborative, decentralized forms of governance, while the Creative Economy Agency functions as a strategic intermediary and platform provider through initiatives such as Bangkok Design Week. Within this environment, Made in Songwat has become an important grassroots organizer, using events, guidebooks, walking tours, and social media campaigns to translate external programs into community-based placemaking practices.
- The interactions between local creative elites, public agencies, and legacy businesses have significantly reshaped Songwat's environment, culture, and economy. Adaptive reuse has regenerated underused buildings and lanes, narratives of "old Songwat" have been reworked into a contemporary creative-heritage identity, and new revenue streams in hospitality, design, and niche retail have emerged alongside the remnants of the traditional wholesale economy. At the same time, the case reveals tensions around uneven visibility and benefit, rising commercialization and cost of living, and growing pressures on more vulnerable residents and tenants.
- In conclusion, the Songwat case shows both the potential and the challenges of creative-led regeneration in a historic commercial neighborhood. Creative entrepreneurs and networks can play a positive role in preserving and reshaping urban heritage, especially when supported by flexible policies and collaborative approaches that value local initiative rather than top-down control. These insights help frame the discussion in the following subsections, which outline the thesis's theoretical contributions, reflect on the study's limitations, and suggest directions for future research on creative-led regeneration in historic districts in Bangkok and beyond.

6.2 Suggestions for future researches

- For future researchers interested in Songwat, this thesis provides an early snapshot of an ongoing transformation rather than a definitive account of its long-term effects. Many creative-led regeneration processes were still in the early stages at the time of this research, and large-scale developments such as the AWC project had yet to be completed or fully integrated into the neighborhood's daily life. As a result, some of the more structural effects—on land values, rental trends, business turnover, and the

social composition of residents and workers—are only partially visible in the current research.

- Songwat will probably face another significant wave of change in the next five years, after the AWC project is completed and fully operational, which could impact its physical form, economic structure, and social dynamics in ways that are difficult to accurately forecast from the current perspective point. Future researchers will be better positioned to observe whether and how this large-scale investment impacts the balance between heritage preservation, small-scale creative entrepreneurship, tourism, and everyday livelihoods in the area. Long-term or follow-up studies could use mixed methods to compare pre- and post-AWC conditions, including repeat interviews, qualitative observation, and quantitative indicators like rental prices, property ownership patterns, and business survival rates.
- Future research could include voices and experiences of low-income tenants, workers in remaining wholesale and logistics activities, and residents in surrounding streets who may be impacted by both the creative district branding and the AWC project. Comparative research that compares Songwat to other Bangkok neighborhoods affected by large waterfront or riverfront developments could help determine whether Songwat is an outlier or part of a larger trend in the city's approach to heritage and regeneration. Ultimately, Songwat's story is still unfolding, and future researchers will be critical in documenting how far the neighborhood remains recognizable—or whether it changes dramatically—once current and planned projects are completed.

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